sprung off in the spring time

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38953335.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Original Characters, Perfuma (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Canon, First Time, non-coercive cult, no angst (mostly), Fluff, wrestling as flirting, Useless Lesbians, glimmer says fuck a lot, Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Adora is Bad at Feelings, but they're both getting better, glimmer is maybe the hero here, some ocs that don't matter at all, Equinox, Rituals, Ritual Public Sex, wow that tag already exists, ignoring the science of etheria's 12 moons, this fic is a lot more tame and wholesome than the rating and tags suggest i swear, Dorks in Love, Fake/Pretend Relationship, or is it?????

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by petty_labelle

Summary

A thick silence follows as Glimmer struggles to take in this information.

The savior of the universe. Fell asleep standing. Then tumbled through a building.

Glimmer was *not* trained for this.

Catra begins uncontrollably laughing. Just joyful full-body squeaky laughs that she doesn't even attempt to hide. It seems to actually wake Adora out of her stupor a bit, blushing and staring fondly at Catra as if no one else can see her doing so.

Slowly, the queen looks to Adora and then to Catra. They immediately straighten right up, used to being under the scrutiny of a commanding officer.

"Both of you. Throne room. In two hours."

Glimmer's so so tired of Catra and Adora. The infuriating (yet helpful) decrees, the tireless overworking, the general uselessness and hopeless pining that seems to have followed them since the Heart of Etheria a couple months ago, the *destroying her castle*. With Netossa and Spinnerella, she decides to solve all this by sending them off on a secret mission. They just have to infiltrate a cult of Plumerian citizens and find out some info. And if they stumble into a journey of discoveries along the way, well, that's their own fucking problem.

Notes

baby's first post-canon fic! one of my favorite tropes is when two people who are pining for each other have to pretend that they're a couple, especially for a covert mission. (that episode of x-files where mulder and scully have to move into the suburbs and pretend to be married comes to mind.) not really sure how we got from there to cult but, alas, here we are.

a huge thank you to bakeapie, wildangeline, draconiankatra, and butterfliesinmybrain for trying to help with the science of the moons. and to heretoforsythia and caminante for making me think "oh, this etherian astronomy makes no sense" and therefore there are no rules.

title from jhene aiko's p*$$y fairy

warnings: this is smut. also, cults but they're harmless and nothing resembling brainwashing or anything violent or coercive happens.

once we get past glimmer, the pov switches back and forth here between catra and adora. it always happens in separate paragraphs so it shouldn't be too confusing but just a heads up.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

This is not what Queen Glimmer had been trained for. Her mother had made sure she was prepared for etiquette and governance and ruling fairly.

She was **not** trained to deal with the two most completely fucking *useless* lesbians in the entire known universe.

(Technically, since they never actually made it back to space as planned, and they'd only encountered the Star Siblings and the Prime clones on their first trip, this was true.)

(Though, it's a little funny to think of how incompetent Prime would have been if he was a useless lesbian. Like, all the clones have crushes on each other and can't get any work done cause they're too busy worrying about not standing too close to each other. The whole Hivemind giggling like school girls if anyone's hands accidentally brushed. She'd have to remember to tell that to Bow later.)

"What are you laughing about? This is important!" Catra screams.

Glimmer doesn't care enough to lie. "Lesbians."

She watches as Catra, face full of righteous indignation, freezes and then just looks confused. There's actually something really precious about Confused Catra, bi-colored eyes all big and questioning. The ugly modified maroon and black Horde uniform almost looks too big and grown-up on her for a second.

And then she sneers and Glimmer remembers that this person is the bane of her entire existence. They're on the same side now, true; the queen even trusts Catra to move, live, and work independently around Bright Moon.

The problem is Catra does nothing independently. Someone always ends up dragged into her nonsense.

That someone is almost always Glimmer herself these days, especially when Melog is off taking naps or exploring. Who knew the former Horde Commander was so co-dependent? Maybe they'd all get a break if the person who Catra really wanted to spend time with could get her head out of her ass and stop trying to avoid their hopelessly obvious feelings.

"Why can't you focus?!" Catra accuses.

"Because there are literally thousands of people in this kingdom and you alone take up 50% of my time!"

"I'm protecting everyone because you refuse to," Catra argues. She does that thing that's starting to drive Glimmer out of her mind, where Catra hears herself say a bullshit sentence, decides she likes the sound of it, and then fully leans into it. "Yeah, I'm standing up for what's right here. I'm being a good guy and all that."

"Could you *be* any more full of shit right now?"

Catra grins. "I can certainly try. But no, this is a real thing. You have to have labor laws."

"I'm not potentially shifting our entire economy just so you can have a mandated nap!"

"I think you're being very culturally insensitive," Catra replies, crossing her arms. She raises her nose in the air a little and Glimmer regrets choosing to allow Catra to offer retribution for her crimes, rather than just banishing her to the desert for a decade.

"Your kingdom needs labor laws," Catra repeats slowly, as if she thinks the queen doesn't understand her. Glimmer feels her hands begin to spark unconsciously. "Some of the lords in the north still institute serfdom, for fucks' sake! The least you could do it make

it illegal to not pay your laborers and then give them fucking breaks!”

Ugh. Right. She had meant to do something about all the shitty indentured servitude up there but they were in the middle of a war and yes, it got away from her. As much as she hates to admit it, Catra’s right.

“Fine,” Glimmer sighs. “Draft something. When can you have it done by?”

“When would you need it by?” Catra asks instead.

“You already wrote it, didn’t you?!” She moves to pull at her own hair. “If you already spent time on this, why did you waste *mine* by arguing for 30 minutes?”

“Because I do so enjoy our little visits,” Catra tells her, voice dripping with fake honey sweetness. “Speaking of indentured servitude, any chance you can give me a tally on how many hours I have left on my service?”

Glimmer lets her powers dissipate slowly.

“I’ll have to check with the head of the guards,” she says. “Can you have a copy of your proposal on my desk by-”

She’s interrupted by a loud crack from overhead. It’s piercing. Sounds like the sky is falling.

Glimmer glances up towards the giant crystal skylight but all she can make out is shadows. That's deeply concerning.

The sky *does* begin to fall soon after, glass raining down from the ceiling overhead.

Catra’s instinct is to apparently leap over the desk to save Glimmer. The queen’s instinct is to teleport to grab Catra. All they manage to accomplish is being on opposite sides of the table when all 8-feet of She-Ra, Princess of Power comes falling down

and lands like a stone on the desk. It's made of thick, ancient marble so it doesn't take any damage; the floor around it, on the other hand, looks dented from the impact.

Adora coughs but she’s still alive. Scratched up and dirty, covered in little nicks from the glass, mind you but alive.

She's outstretched on her back, eyes wide and confused as if she doesn't understand this any more than the two people she almost just flattened.

“I’m okay!” she yells weakly.

The other two look to the ceiling, in fight positions already.

“Who are we under attack from?” Catra asks, shaking some glass out of her short hair. “How many are there?”

When the papers in the room begin to swirl around in the large gusts of wind that immediately follow, Glimmer panics. Spinnerella? Has she been chipped again?

The princess enters through the now-gaping hole created in the roof of Glimmer’s study. She looks worried, a human emotion and one that someone under mind control probably can’t conjure up.

“Did you kick Adora’s ass through the ceiling?” Catra sounds a little too excited about that idea. “Cause, respect.”

“No!” Spinny is almost offended at the idea. She lands softly next to them. “We were working on the damage done by the clones over the war room. Adora may have stumbled.”

Her eyes are all fidgety, the godsdamn liar.

That...is physically impossible. The war room is nowhere *near* Glimmer’s study.

“Stumbled?” Glimmer parrots back. “Several feet? Halfway across the castle?”

“Fine,” Spinnerella huffs. “She fell asleep on her feet, tripped, rolled a bit, and just kind of went down. I don't think the glass dome was prepared for that much weight.”

A thick silence follows as Glimmer struggles to take in this information.

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Glimmer was ***not*** trained for this.

Catra begins uncontrollably laughing. Just joyful full-body squeaky laughs that she doesn't even attempt to hide. It seems to actually wake Adora out of her stupor a bit, blushing and staring fondly at Catra as if no one else can see her doing so.

Glimmer takes a deep breath and sends a silent prayer to her ancestors for strength and patience.

Slowly, the queen looks to Adora and then to Catra. They immediately straighten right up, used to being under the scrutiny of a commanding officer.

“Both of you. Throne room. In two hours.”

Catra and Spinnerella spend the break trying to wrestle She-Ra into lying down for a quick nap. It almost works because she’s been a lot more gentle with Catra since she came to Bright Moon. But just because Adora isn’t throwing her face-first into walls anymore doesn’t mean she’s above “defending” herself as she keeps calling it, swinging haymakers at both Catra and Spinnerella to keep them back.

Eventually Catra calls Melog for backup. They transform into a 9-foot tall cat and just sit on She-Ra while she throws a tantrum like a giant baby.

She gets about 10 minutes of sleep once she finally calms down.

Adora starts talking before she's even all the way in the door. This looks bad from the outside but if Glimmer will just let her explain, she'll understand. Adora didn't *fall asleep.* She's pretty sure she fainted, maybe? Of dehydration or something else that won't get her banished from working again. They made her take a week off last month and all she managed to do was get carpal tunnel. Catra kept teasing her, particularly for waking up at dawn on her days off to do useless perimeter checks, and Adora wasn't allowed in the training room so she had a lot of *frustrations* to work out alone in her room. In her bed.

"Glimmer, I swear that everything's fine. I just need to drink more wa-"

Adora stops when she sees her two best friends. Glimmer is on the throne, head in hand. Catra is perched precariously on one of the magical floating stairs that leads up to it. Usually Glimmer would yell at Catra to get down and show more respect. This time, she looks too tired to even try.

This is much worse than Adora thought.

"Adora," Glimmer begins. "Great. Now that you're both here-"

"*Why* are we here exactly?" Catra interrupts. From the way her tail is lazily just lofting in the air, Adora knows she's being playful but Glimmer hasn't had the liberty of watching Catra for her entire life to learn all of her tells.

The queen stands up quickly, ready to yell. Adora rushes forward.

"She's joking!" the blonde yells awkwardly. She forces herself to laugh to really get the point across. "Catra's joking. We're both here. Ready for orders, Your Majesty."

Catra throws Adora a look over her shoulder. She had, in fact, been joking. Why was this weirdo being so strange about it? Sparkles was annoyed, sure. But *Catra* wasn't the one who broke

her study. She assumed she was just present to be gifted custody of Adora or something.

No-n-not that Catra would *want* that necessarily. Generous offer, though. And you can't say no to a royal decree.

Glimmer throws herself back into her throne. "You two have to leave."

Catra feels her face fall. She'd been there for over two months, helping these assclowns fix their stupid fucking kingdoms and she was just being tossed out like the trash now. And with Adora?! They couldn't just *throw* She-Ra away, could they?

"Hey! Fuck-"

"You're going on a mission," Glimmer continues. "A secret mission that only a carefully chosen few know about. I've gone over this with Spinnerella and Netossa, and they'll be bringing you up to speed fully. I've already had your bags packed for you."

Adora nods along. "Okay. What's the target?"

"There's a small cult currently stationed slightly south of Thaymor, in the valley between Talon Mountain and the Singing River. I don't think they're dangerous yet, but I'm going to need you two to go undercover and do some recon. Most of Etheria doesn't quite know your names or certainly what you look like. Just no She-Ra. *Everyone* fucking knows She-Ra."

Catra watches as Adora moves to hold her chin, taking this all in with her serious 'mission' face. There's just one huge issue though.

"I don't do cults," Catra grumbles.

Glimmer gives her a soft smile. "This one's different. It's *people,* first of all. Etherians. I just want to make sure they're not up to something. So far, they seem peaceful. But I want some assurance they'll stay that way."

She teleports herself down to the stair in front of Catra's and takes a seat.

"Look, after what we went through…" She doesn't mention him by name but Catra knows she's referring to Prime, "I would never do anything to put you in a similar position."

Slowly, Catra says, "Alright. Undercover? Sounds juicy. How long?"

"A couple of weeks probably."

"A couple of *weeks?"* Adora shrieks. "But I'm in the middle of-"

"Destroying my home?!" Glimmer yells. "The briefing is in the war room. Try to take the door and not the fucking ceilling entrance, Adora."

Glimmer teleports away immediately.

The briefing is a fucking joke. Literally. Netossa doesn't stop trying to (badly) hide a laugh the entire time. She knows something but she's not giving it away, no matter how much Catra tries to bait her into spilling.

Spinerella takes it much more seriously. Adora's relieved by that. She has maps and a brief history of the area and some background on the Cult of Eras. They don't sound very dangerous. Most of them are Plumerian citizens who splintered off, somehow more interested in peace and free love than even those hippies.

Adora's not sure why Glimmer didn't just send Perfuma instead?

Spinerella's last piece of information is, "Just relax. When you get there, try going with the flow."

She does a weird dance, moving all of her limbs lazily. Finally, Netossa laughs out loud.

So Adora and Catra set off. It's only sorta awkward. They're more like acquaintances than friends these days anyway. In the brief lull between the Heart and fixing Etheria, they took Perfuma's advice and spent some time talking about growing up and their experiences on separate sides of the war. Their feelings about the Horde and Shadow Weaver. The resentment of each other that she sowed. Not much else.

Maybe if they'd followed through and gone to space, things would have been easier. Trapped on a ship together could have given them more time to focus and go deep. But there was work to be done at home and so adventures and time alone (without any other Best Friend Squad members popping in constantly) would have to wait.

...til now, it seems.

The plan is to ride Swift Wind to Thaymor then march down the rest of the way so that they don't bring attention to themselves.

The march sounds wonderful to Catra cause their ride won't stop running his mouth.

"For a while, I was hanging out in Mystacor. I was a big hit out there. *Big* hit. Magic people love a magic horse," Swift Wind rambles as he's been doing for the past hour.

"Does anyone like a silent horse?" Catra asks. "Cause I sure would."

"Well, fortunately, I am a *talking* steed. You're free to hitch another ride that's more to your liking. Not sure how many flying horses are out there. Oh, wait – just *me."*

"Swifty," Adora admonishes.

He grumbles to himself about the mean cat. When Adora feels Catra's weight shifting behind her, she almost freaks out, thinking the girl might actually try to take Swift Wind's advice. Except, Adora soon has claws on her shoulder, followed by Catra hoisting

herself over the blonde's body til she's seated in her lap, face-to-face. It's more of a straddle really.

"*Hey,* Adora," Catra purrs.

"*Hey,* Catra," Adora mocks. With a teasing lilt to her voice, she adds, "I don't think this is an appropriate riding position."

Catra raises an eyebrow devilishly. "Depends on what kind of riding you're planning."

"I'm just gonna go ahead and land now," Swift Wind loudly announces.

Adora keeps one hand in Swift Wind's mane to steady herself but uses the other to pull Catra closer by the shoulders. They've always been super touchy with each other. With Catra back in her life, Adora finds a lot of comfort in being able to touch and be close again. After their time on Darla, Glimmer even stopped commenting about it.

"You should hold on tighter. For safety, of course," Adora warns.

"Of course." Catra wraps her legs around Adora's waist.

That's actually a bit *closer* than they usually are. Catra's smiling like she wants Adora to keep teasing her. But really all the blonde can think to say is-

"We're gonna have to sleep in the same bed tonight."

Catra hums her acknowledgement of that. "Is that okay with you?" she asks. She doesn't know why her voice sounds so tiny. They've shared a bed for years. Catra thought it would be the same in Bright Moon.

Well, technically they *do* both sleep in Adora's bed. The blonde just only seems to enter it after Catra's already asleep and then is up before she wakes. Except for that weird week that Glimmer put

Adora on a break and the door was magically locked every time Catra swung by for a midday nap.

“Yeah, definitely,” Adora replies. “Totally cool with that.”

Catra can hear how panicked Adora sounds even if the blonde is completely unaware.

She removes her arm from Catra’s shoulder to give her a very awkward pat on the back. It's probably supposed to be reassuring so Catra tries to smile.

To Adora, it looks more like a wince. Swift Wind saves them by landing soon after.

The walk to where the Cult of Eras has made camp is pretty quiet. Neither of them wastes much time and there's at least a couple occasions where Catra challenges Adora to race her to the next mark up ahead. Adora enjoys that – it reminds her of how they used to be together, without any bitterness of having to compete *for* something. Or *someone.*

She does feel a bit bad that Catra doesn't get to enjoy the wilderness around them. Since coming to Bright Moon, she's mostly been inside the castle, working non-stop. Maybe after this is over, assuming they don't have captives or anything, Adora could suggest they walk back to their kingdom, pausing to camp and take in the sights. Glimmer already gave them time off, Adora just has to make sure they end this mission early. But safely. Thoroughly.

Right, this is the problem. Everytime Adora starts to think of all the things she wants to do with Catra, she gets sloppy and forgets about the missions and her purpose. She lets herself be carried away by all the dreams she and Catra used to have. They were vague as children, but now that she’s seen all of Etheria (and parts of the wider universe), Adora can’t help spending time imagining everything they could do together. Travel and learn new things and... *explore...*

But Etheria needs She-Ra, not Adora. Best to focus on all the work to be done.

She might not have passed out from exhaustion or dehydration earlier so much as gotten distracted by a daydream about going to back to her room early and finding Catra already there, touching hers-

Catra watches in horror and amusement as Adora, a person who claims to have perfect situational awareness at all times, trips over a small bunch of purple mushrooms trailing from under the shade of a huge, leafy tree.

The dummy goes down hard without even enough time to break her fall and lands face-first on the ground. The huge pack Adora insisted on bringing with her, full of Gods know what, practically buries her like a cement brick.

“The mighty She-Ra defeated by a fungus,” Catra says with a laugh.

Adora huffs quietly from the ground. At least she didn't break her nose. She's not supposed to actually take She-Ra out on this mission unless things go really wrong so she wouldn't be able to transform and heal herself. She can just imagine Catra laughing at her for the next several days if her face were to form into a giant purple bruise.

“What were you doing? Daydreaming about the next mission to save Etheria?”

Adora lies there just a little longer so Catra can't see her blush.

The closer they get to camp, the more Adora readies herself for a surprise attack. She's expecting guards or magic illusions or trained woodland beasts. It isn't until they're right on top of a couple of tents that the princess realizes there's no present threat.

It's a few hours until the night moons rise probably, but Catra can't see or hear anyone in the distance working. A camp this size, around a dozen tents hidden by the trees that she can make out with her superior vision, should have people grabbing water or chopping wood or something. She can hear some talking. Some *singing and drumming.* Ugh. Hippies.

Catra wonders what these people were into that made some of them not compatible with the rest of Plumeria. Losing themselves in the rhythm *too* much? Not improvising enough? Suggesting the music could use a string section?

Adora hears Catra snort to herself. This only confirms that they're not taking this mission serious enough.

“Are you picking anything up?” she asks.

“Just music. Also smells. There's...a lot of smells.”

“Is that bad? Are they bad smells?”

“Not any worse than a cadet class after a survival training weekend,” Catra says.

Adora turns up her nose cutely. Catra has to look away to hide her smile.

They're still 100 feet or so away. She can feel the blonde tensing up even more.

“We're travelers, Adora,” she whispers, just in case there's any unnoticed security. “Try looking less like a soldier.”

“I'm being totally cool.” Her words come out grunted from how hard she's balling her fists and preparing for a fight.

Sighing quietly, Catra stops walking and grabs Adora’s hand, yanking her until her feet stop moving. Adora’s hands are even more calloused than usual from all the recent physical labor of the rebuild.

Catra's about to say something but she gets a little distracted by how cute Adora looks in her little red jumpsuit thing that Glimmer made her wear. It's sleeveless, a tanktop and shorts combo that's reminiscent of She-Ra's old costume minus the stupid billowing skirt. Gods know why Sparkles dressed Catra in a leather jacket and a pants-version of the same outfit. She looks badass though and Adora did turn a little pink when Catra came out and hopped confidently onto Swift Wind.

"Um…" Adora starts nervously, "Is there a reason why you grabbed me?" She glances down to where Catra is still holding her hand. Not that she has any complaints. "Wait, do you hear someone coming?" She starts looking around, back on high alert.

"You have to chill," Catra tells her. "We're just doing recon. Try turning off 'warrior mode' for a couple days."

"Sure. How do you do that?"

She still looks way too worried about something that should come natural to most people. But Adora's not exactly 'most people' so Catra patiently takes her other hand.

"Unball your fists, for one." Once that's done, she moves up to Adora's shoulder. If her claws lightly tease along Adora's bare arms on the way, neither of them mentions it. "Relax your stance. Maybe try *not* having perfect posture for once."

"But you know how hard I worked on that," Adora whines. Catra *must* remember how she struggled with that when they were 8. Shadow Weaver repeatedly told her that she had to sit up straight and Adora spent months working to make sure she never ever slouched, not once.

Catra just rolls her eyes. "Yeah, what adversity you had to overcome there," she sarcastically mumbles. "Why don't you imagine you're playing a character? A regular, young hip character traveling with her gorgeous and very cool girlfriend."

Adora snorts. Catra was never lacking in confidence, at least. It was one of the best things about her. Lately, she'd been just storming into meetings and making decrees. It was driving Glimmer out of her mind but a lot of Catra's ideas were brilliant and made Etheria a better place. Adora was proud to be her...friend. Pretend girlfriend now.

"Stop biting your lip like that."

Adora immediately releases it. She hadn't even noticed.

"Is that not what a hip person would do?"

"No, it's…" Distracting. Hot. "...annoying," Catra finishes.

"You're annoying," Adora replies quickly.

"I'd fight you right now but I'm afraid you'll cheat and bring out She-Ra and this whole thing will be ruined."

Adora pretends to get a good laugh out of that. "I don't need She-Ra to win a fight against you."

"True. You need She-Ra *and* a whole army of princesses," Catra says with a smirk. Adora can just see the tip of one of her fangs. She suddenly remembers that Catra's hands are still on her shoulders, warm and soft.

"Oh, Catra," Adora says slowly, bringing her right hand up to gently place it on top of the claw on her shoulder. Catra's brow furrows in confusion. It gets even deeper when Adora's left hand reaches up to caress her cheek. She watches those big two-tone eyes get wide, Catra's tail starting to swish side-to-side behind her.

Maybe a moment too late, Catra realizes what's happening. Adora's dumb ocean blue eyes always smirk just a second before her lips do. Suddenly, the soft grasp on her hand turns into an iron grip. If there was more time, Catra would call her out for

being so predictable. Adora forgets that she was *there* when the blonde learned this trick in training.

Adora wrenches Catra's hand off of her shoulder, attempting to spin it upside-down and into a wristlock. At the same time, she slips from Catra's cheek to the back of her neck in a familiar grappling move.

Catra just follows the motion of her wrist, letting herself go boneless to twist as needed. The world turns on its axle as Catra does a one-armed cartwheel to the side. Before Adora can shift her weight to counter, Catra delivers a roundhouse kick directly onto the giant pack. With so much force (and so much heavy junk in there), Adora ends up face-down on the ground again as Catra slips her hand away.

"Oh, Adora," she mimics. "Still the slowest person on the planet."

"You folks okay?" someone calls out in a deep, rumbling but very friendly voice.

Catra laughs. "Yeah, my *girlfriend* is just playing around."

Adora isn't quite sure if it's the thrill of hearing Catra call her that or the adrenaline of a possible new threat posed by this stranger but she vaults up to her feet. Next to her, Catra's playing it cool but she can tell that's all a facade. Almost imperceptibly, Catra's eyes are narrowed, annoyed that someone spotted her before she spotted them.

Much further ahead, two people peek out from a thicket of tall trees. There's a tall, thickly-built person, resembling a human woman, with mahogany-colored skin, low-trimmed hair, and a bright, confused smile. She's dressed in a pair of tan overalls with no shirt. The other, an equally thick person who's about a half-foot shorter, with lilac skin and jet black eyes, stands just behind her. Her blue sundress flows in the light breeze, reminding Adora of the type of person she expected to see here.

The strangers begin to walk closer to them.

“You all lost?” the taller one asks.

Taking Catra’s hand, Adora starts closing the distance between the two pairs.

“Sorta,” Catra jumps in to reply. She exchanges a quick look with Adora, confirming that she’ll take the lead. “We’ve been traveling around for a bit. Heard that if we were ever in this area, there might be some people who could offer us a warm meal or two.”

For a long moment, the two strangers just examine them with their eyes.

“Traveling from where?” the shorter woman asks.

“Lotsa places,” Catra answers shortly. “We’re making our way towards Thaymor right now. Don’t really have an end destination in mind.”

The taller one nods.

“I’m Adora!” the princess shouts across the remaining 20 or so feet.

Catra has to bite her cheek to keep from rolling her eyes. ‘Friendly’ was not the vibe she was going for. They’re a cult. They’re secretive. People there have things to hide so you have to act like you’re running from something too. Make yourself seem vulnerable so they can present themselves as your last hope. That’s how you get in deeper.

It suddenly occurs to Catra that she should maybe start an espionage unit of Bright Moon’s military when they get back, convinced that Glimmer would hate that.

“This is Catra. She’s much sweeter than she seems.”

Catra allows herself to groan aloud. Maybe she should just start by teaching Adora at least *one thing* about being a spy first.

The taller one laughs. “What a familiar sound,” she says, bumping her friend with her hip. “I’m Hess and this is Livi, inventor of the embarrassed groan.”

“Nice to meet you!” Adora shoots forward to shake both of their hands. These two seem harmless enough (she, of course, did a visual weapons check first) and she thinks she’s doing a pretty good job of pretending to be nice.

Catra gives a short nod instead of moving from her current spot.

“Come on,” Livi orders. Her voice is neutral and Adora wonders if she’s just trying to match Catra’s aloofness. “Let’s go see if we can figure out if we’re the folks you’re looking for.”

Without pause, she turns and heads back towards the two tents Adora could just barely see. They’re nestled in the trees a bit but she imagines that there must be a small clearing up ahead. To the left, she can still see Talon Mountain looming up in the air, all dark and broody. And pointy. It’s weirdly pointy. To their right is mostly forest but she hopes they’ll get a chance to explore. Somewhere around there is the Singing River and Adora wants to finally learn if the legends are true and it actually sings.

Catra hates water. And serenades, which they’ve learned from their time with Sea Hawk and Scorpia. It’s the perfect landscape for teasing her endlessly until she makes her cute little frowny face.

“Where are you both from?” Adora asks, to distract herself from cataloging which of Catra’s facial expressions is the cutest. That’s been an insistent thought at the back of her head for the past couple months now.

“Lotsa places,” Livi replies, though she throws Adora a look over her shoulder that makes Catra smirk.

Adora nods. “How long have you two been out here?”

"Longer than you've been carrying that pack around," Livi responds. "Thing looks pretty heavy. You expect me to believe you've been on the road hauling that around for long?"

Catra grits her teeth. She didn't bring more than a brown canvas knapsack – water, a bit of rations (Bright Moon rations to be clear, which are actually quite delicious, with its cured meats and such), and the essentials. *Adora,* on the other hand, seems to have brought every single thing in the castle. Her bag probably weighs more than Catra, judging by how her calves and thighs flex with each step.

The princess chuckles. "Trust me, heavy things aren't an issue for me. I'm in pretty good shape," she says in a way that's clearly meant to be casual but is undermined with her flexing both biceps. "Plus, I've been carrying this one," she pauses to point at Catra, "around my whole life so I've had practice."

Catra half-sneers, tearing her eyes away from Adora's dumb muscles.

"Watch it, princess. You're making it sound like I've been riding your coattails."

"I mean *literally* carrying her because she refuses to use her legs half the time," Adora clarifies. "Last week, she *rolled* to bed."

Before Catra can argue that the bed was not a distance that required walking and, therefore, was beneath her, Livi questions, "Princess?"

"Can't you tell what a spoiled brat she is?" Catra pokes into where Adora has a half-dimple that you can only see when she's smiling really brightly or in the middle of a full-body laugh.

"Me?" Adora questions incredulously. "Did you not hear the part about you rolling to bed?"

"Do you not remember how you *whined* about how much work you had left to do until you bored me to sleep that night?" It was

an all-too-common excuse for why Adora would have to join her in bed later.

Adora reaches over to swat at Catra, who dodges and shifts so that her tail tickles at the blonde's nose.

Quietly enough that probably only Catra hears it, Hess whispers, "Still think they're not in the right place?"

Livi gives them a surreptitious look. "We'll see."

The clearing is fucking huge.

Those two small tents up front must just be for folks keeping watch or to throw off intruders, Catra imagines. This spot – the *real* spot – is situated on a gorgeous piece of mostly flat, lush green grass. She counts at least a dozen tents made out of hides, deer-skin rugs and down mattresses hidden inside them, and a table of fruit, roasted meats, and wine set off to the side. Catra wonders where they got all this.

The whole place is centered around a large fire pit and surrounded on all sides by thick trees and looming mountains. Lots of privacy, she thinks.

Adora can appreciate the set up. They're all obviously very self-sufficient and able to take care of each other. Hard work is important. She just kinda appreciates the fruit of that hard work more – all of the bulging biceps that greet her and Catra as Hess and Livi introduce them.

Adora's never seen this many beautiful women in one place. Tall, muscular women that Catra barely hides a sneer at. Curvy elfin women that she thinks Catra's eyes linger on. Women of every shape, size, and color, over 2 dozen of them, all gorgeous and friendly. There's a bit of range in age, with folks who look every bit as youthful as Catra and Adora up to a few people, like Hess and Livi, who have 5 or so more years on them.

They’re all extremely nice but you kinda have to be if you’re trying to trick people into joining your cult. Regardless, Adora does some amazing acting as she asks them all questions about whatever random task that Hess interrupts to present the newcomers.

Catra’s never gonna be able to keep up with this many names. She can barely remember to attempt to smile at each person. Plus, Adora’s being nice enough for both of them, practically drooling all over everyone.

“-e look out for each other and care for each other. We’re all about community,” Hess is explaining.

Livi is too busy not very discreetly examining Catra’s face. She has to force herself to look more neutral. All of this hippie talk is just making her more tense about being there in a cult full of gorgeous women, at least half of whom are looking at Adora like a piece of roasted meat.

Adora places a hand on Catra’s shoulder gently. Her tail is lashing angrily and it’s starting to make the others nervous.

“That sounds lovely,” Adora tells Hess. “Everyone’s so nice and welcoming. This place is amazing.”

The larger woman gives her a big smile, excited for her fake enthusiasm. “Are you two hungry?”

That’s something both Catra and Adora can actually show some eagerness for.

“You arrived just in time,” Livi says, still eyeing them suspiciously. “Everyone was just wrapping up dinner.”

They’re sat at the table that Adora had noticed earlier, except it’s almost overflowing with a bounty of food now. More meats, fresh vegetables, and loaves of bread have been added and Adora hears her stomach rumble in anticipation.

Hess explains how they have hunting parties, a group of people who are in charge of foraging, a separate group that cooks, and another that cleans. Catra almost laughs hearing it. The regiment sounds like the Horde. Guess all that hippie shit goes out the window when people want to ensure that they're eating.

Catra makes sure she lets their hosts taste everything first, watching them closely.

Adora just jumps in and stuffs her face full of every single thing that's offered to her. Even with her mouth full, she keeps up most of the conversation for the duo, asking everyone questions and listening with interest. It takes Adora a while to notice but after a couple hours of getting to know everyone, she realizes that she's not even thinking about rebuilding efforts, just focused on this mission. That's the first time that's happened in months.

"So," someone begins, waving between the two of them. "Are you together?" It's...Ako, maybe? It's hard to remember with all of the new information but Adora thinks the robust, human-like person with horns is called Ako.

"Yep," Adora confirms with a smile.

Spinerella had stressed that this was the cover – they were a young couple just traveling around, enjoying the renewed magic of Etheria. Try to keep everything as close to the truth as possible, Netossa had suggested, since Adora was so bad at lying. No one mentioned that they'd be *lying* about being a couple. Maybe Spinnerella and Netossa just assumed that part was true?

Adora tries to think of 'couple things' to do to sell this. She settles for immediately throwing her arm around Catra's shoulders.

Catra now has this dummy plastered to her for the rest of the meal. When Adora notices something she thinks they should keep an eye on – like that the seat at the head of the table is empty or the one person carrying a large knife – she whispers it into Catra's ear. Everytime, Catra feels her eyes slipping closed at the gentle

little breaths and having Adora's warmth so close. And then she has to snap out of it and focus.

Around dinner, people casually talk about where they're from or what they do for the group. Their plans for tomorrow. Their excitement about the equinox. What surprises they think Eras has planned for the ceremony.

Catra's ears perk up at 'ceremony.' That sounds appropriately cult-ish and suspect.

"Who's Eras?" Adora asks instead. There wasn't anything in the briefing mentioning that Eras was a *person.*

From behind them, a silky-smooth voice purrs, "That would be me, beloved."

Adora and Catra turn to see a tall figure, at least 6 feet. Thin and lithe yet toned. Skin so black it's almost blue. Shiny jet black hair that travels to their waist. She's wearing only a piece of ivory-colored fabric, tied over her left shoulder to keep it on and ending several inches above her knee.

Power. That's all Catra can feel coming from this person. She's not sure if it's magic or something else but this person is teeming with it. No surprise Glimmer's worried about what the group is capable of. Just being in her presence makes Catra's fur stand up a bit.

She's been around power like this her whole life really. And Catra's tried just about everything: appease it, manipulate it, steal it for herself, fight it. She and Adora are just supposed to keep an eye on all this power but it would be nice to get away from here as soon as possible. Well, as soon as the mission's over maybe.

"Welcome to Eraspolis," the person greets, sounding like Glimmer when she tries to remind everyone that she's queen. "I am Eras, keeper of this land. You have met my people. Allow me to meet you now."

Adora lets the arm around Catra's shoulder tighten. She has a good feeling about everyone else here. Eras, not so much.

"I'm Adora. This is Catra."

Eras gives them both a long look before going to sit at the head of the table. "You are weary travelers?"

"Oh yeah," Adora nods, ignoring Catra's ever so slightly narrowed eyes. "Super weary."

It's harder to ignore when claws press into her thigh.

Catra cuts in, "Seems like you've got a whole set up here. We don't want to be in the way. We're grateful for dinner but we tend to keep to ourselves on the road. We'll just make camp somewhere nearby and probably head off early tomorrow."

"Keeping to ourselves has been getting really old lately, Catra," Adora argues. "Building some community might be good for us."

Catra opens her mouth to find some excuse why they can't be here at nighttime but Eras cuts her off.

"Nonsense," Eras says with an easy smile. "We have plenty of room. Relax. Have some wine. And then we'll see how you're feeling."

Adora doesn't have a chance to decline before two full clay goblets are placed in front of them. The liquid inside is rose-colored and filled almost to the brim. Even just the smell of it – boozy and floral – makes Adora's head swim a bit.

Catra watches Taff, a thin, pale-skinned fawn with green hair and matching eyes, hand out goblets to everyone.

"To passion," Eras says, raising her glass.

Along with everyone else, Adora takes a sip. The brew coats the inside of her mouth nicely, different from the thin red wines

served at the castle. She fakes a second drink to discreetly spit it back into the cup, though.

Catra waits until she's confirmed that everyone else has imbibed before venturing a taste. It's sweet. She absolutely *loves* sweets, thanks to the time she spent with Entrapta.

All around them, the group breaks into a gentle-flowing conversation. Dinners at Bright Moon usually do dual-duty as brainstorming sessions, if people can even find time to break away from their work to join. 'People' generally just means 'Adora,' who often grabs a handful of food and rushes off quickly.

Eras talks to everyone about their day, casually checking in on how things are running in their camp. Catra can see how at ease she makes them all. She doesn't share that feeling. A couple sips of wine should help her relax enough to fake it.

The conversation continues as dinner draws to a close, the group stuffed but not sluggish, all lively and joking. Nothing of interest is talked about and Adora's not sure if it's because outsiders are present. She remains alert anyway, tracking everyone's movements, keeping an eye on the clearing and what she can see of the woods.

A mint-colored eel from Salineas named Gin is telling a long-winded story about sailing when Catra's head slumps onto Adora's shoulder with a thud. Gin freezes and there's a moment of strange silence where Adora has to fight not to panic. Were they drugged? Catra had been acting suspicious about everything they were served – maybe she was right.

Soon, though, everyone breaks out into a jovial, tipsy laugh. Even Livi lightens up for a second.

"Beloveds," Eras calls out, amusement evident in her voice. "Did you not explain to our young visitors that the wine is quite...potent?"

Adora tries to crane to see Catra's face without disturbing her too much. "You okay?"

Catra blinks, once quickly and one slower, before she can shift her eyes up to meet Adora's. They're a little glassy but soft and relaxed. Her plump lips are slightly parted, quirked up into a faint smile. It reminds Adora of how vulnerable and serene Catra looks when she's sleeping, a sight that she relishes when she sneaks into bed at night. Catra always instinctively reaches for her then and Adora always reaches back, holding hands until she nods off herself.

"'m okay," Catra whispers. Her voice sounds just a little extra raspy. Maybe a bit slurred. It's ridiculously cute.

"We don't drink much," Adora explains to the table. That earns another laugh.

"Perhaps you'll reconsider my offer to spend the night?" Eras asks.

Livi's face twitches just a bit.

Adora looks back to Catra for an answer. All she gets is a drowsy, "Mmroww?"

She's never seen Catra drunk. For a moment, there's that sadness that comes when Adora remembers that there's a 3-year gap in her knowledge of her best friend. It's possible Catra had some adventure when she was in the Crimson Waste or celebratory drinks after one of her victories over the Rebellion. But they don't talk in details about those things – Catra has a healer person or something that she talks to as part of her retribution plan – and Adora doesn't know how to navigate any good that might have happened over that period without accidentally stumbling into a landmine.

With a sigh, Adora lets the hand that she has lain on Catra's shoulder trail up towards her ears for a brief scratch. Her hair is longer now, shaggy and almost falling across her eyes when it's not combed back. Adora's fingers get lost on their way and Catra's

leans into that touch, releasing a short purr. She melts into Adora's side more.

Hess makes a sound that reminds her of Bow, a sort of cooing. "I'll grab your bags and set you up with a tent. Don't think it's gonna be easy for you to make camp tonight carrying her around."

"Not carrying me," Catra mumbles. Her breath tickles Adora's neck.

"No, that's okay," Adora says, voice so much higher than usual. "We can handle it."

But Hess is already on her feet and retrieving both of their bags from where they left them. Without another word, she begins heading off in darkness and Adora *could* pick up Catra and chase after her. It's just that Adora's knees feel weird or something. Unsteady. That's how she gets when she thinks too much about Catra or watches her smile or apparently has her purring into Adora's neck.

"I insist," Eras tells her.

Earlier, when she was awake, Adora felt Catra's fur bristling and slightly fidgeting at Eras' presence. Catra's intuition is always so good that there's no choice but to trust her. And Adora does, completely; she just also trusts her own ability to get out of trouble if anything happens. Half the group is drunker than Catra is anyway, slowly starting to fall asleep at the table or mumbling nonsense or talking about heading to bed soon.

They're safe to stay the night. That's what Glimmer would want them to do.

"Okay. Thank you."

Eras smiles brightly. "So polite. Livi, can you show Adora where they'll be staying?"

Livi nods and quickly finishes her own wine.

“You’ll want to retire early and get your rest,” Eras adds. “Tomorrow is an exciting day. The vernal equinox.”

Unsure what exactly that means, Adora asks, “Is there anything we should prepare for the ceremony? Anything to study maybe?”

They wouldn’t want to stick out. Plus, maybe there’s some materials that’ll give her insight on what exactly these people are about.

Eras shakes her head, her smile going a little condescending. “No, nothing to prepare. Trust me. Tomorrow, you’ll just want to do what comes... *naturally.”*

Adora has to half-carry Catra to the tent that she's directed to. Catra's extra sleepy and can only manage about half her weight. With her arm around Adora's neck and her feet slightly shuffling forward, the blonde keeps an arm around Catra's waist to stick close to her side.

Livi and Hess try not to look too amused as they guide their two visitors. Occasionally, they glance back before sharing a secret grin. Catra's going to be freaking livid about this in the morning when she sobers up. She'd never let anyone laugh at any sign of weakness in the past.

...assuming she can remember this tomorrow morning, Adora thinks. A small chuckle escapes her. The former Horde leader, toppled by two glasses of honey wine. She'd have to ask to take a bottle back with them. It was kinda nice to get to take care of Catra.

The tents they're led to are clustered a little further away from the rest of camp. There's only three back here, hidden in this corner. Two of them are dark but the third has a small glow emanating from it that makes it seem warm and cozy after a long day of working then the briefing then rushing here before sunset.

Oh, Gods, Adora thinks. Was that all just one day? Either it's the exhaustion or Eras' weird presence but time seems to feel differently.

Catra must feel it too because as soon as Livi pulls back the entrance, Catra stumbles into the tent and drops herself face-down on the surprisingly plush looking mattress pad. It's not nearly as fancy as an Alliance camp but their accommodations are spacious, tall enough to stand without crouching, and decorated with a bed barely wide enough to hold the two of them that's covered in blankets and pillows. Eras does seem the type to be into comfort.

Hess leaves their bags next to the bed and politely crosses back out the threshold of the tent.

"We thought it would be best to give you one a little further away from the crowd," she explains. "For privacy."

"Thanks," Adora tells her genuinely. It'll be harder to spy but at least they'll have more opportunities for planning and debriefing.

Behind her, Catra whines out something that sounds vaguely like her name.

Livi has to purse her lips to hide her smirk. "We'll leave you to it then. Night, kids."

"Goodnight," Adora replies, though she doesn't particularly like being considered a child.

She's *She-Ra,* after all. She defeated Horde Prime. Saved the universe. Brought back the stars and yada yada. Hess and Livi are already gone and Adora wouldn't be able to tell them any of this anyway.

Letting the tent fall closed, Adora waits for another second to make sure they're alone before turning to begin getting ready for bed.

Thank the Gods they actually *are* alone because Adora screams as soon as she moves into the tent. Standing – not lying in bed, not whining, but standing! – an inch from her face is Catra, calm as day.

"What's your problem?" she asks, as if she didn't just appear like a ghost out of thin air. At least Glimmer makes a noise when she teleports in.

"I thought you were asleep!" Adora yells. She winces as she hears how loud she is. "Sorry. You just seemed really drunk."

Catra shakes her head slowly. *Too* slowly. It takes several seconds just for her to move it side to side.

"I was faking," she says, slurring slightly.

To prove how clearly correct she is, Catra's body then sways a little. Adora reaches out to steady her and all she gets for her trouble is a hiss.

"Mostly faking," Catra amends. "Very largely faking, even. I was pretending to let my guard down."

Adora watches her struggle to stand while politely only laughing on the inside. "Yeah, you're such a good actress, you've also fooled yourself."

"Thank you," Catra replies, before pretending to bow her head. Her body isn't quite prepared for that move and she nearly falls over again. "It's hot in here."

"It's actually pretty chil-" Adora has to swallow the rest of her words as Catra tosses off her jacket and begins to tug her jumpsuit off in one motion. Adora's feet understand that it would be polite to look away, and since her eyes don't intend on listening to that, her whole body shifts itself to face the opposite wall.

In Bright Moon, Catra sleeps in some of Adora's old clothes, usually just a random shirt and some shorts. Adora's almost never there when she prepares for bed. It didn't really occur to her that she'd have to be present for it now. Two weeks of close shared quarters where they'll have to bathe and get ready together and be all domestic.

Adora's stomach feels like it's full of live fish all of a sudden.

There's a soft thump, which probably means Catra's back in bed already. She rustles around a bit, hitting pillows and grumbling how it's way too warm in a room that's definitely still full of the light spring chill.

"Come on, dummy," she calls out. "It's perfect now."

Adora finds that hard to believe – perfect beds are not usually in the middle of a cult – but she follows anyway. She snuffs out the lamp before beginning her own bedtime ritual. Clothes off and folded neatly in the corner. Hair let down from her ponytail. Knife stashed under the pillow.

Catra huffs the entire time, lying on her side facing towards the wall. For someone who keeps claiming to be overheated, she's got a soft knitted blanket covered up to her neck.

In only her standard-issued gray underwear now, Adora gently slides under the covers and into the bed. Catra has the whole thing set up just how she likes with the pillows extra fluffy and the additional blankets rolled up around her to create a little nest. It's a little piece of home that almost helps keep Adora calm.

Between the tall trees nearby and the looming Talon Mountain, there's not much moonlight filtering into the tent. Catra can probably see pretty well but Adora has to wait until her eyes adjust to the darkness in order to make out the huddled figure next to her, curled halfway into a ball.

On their trip home after her rescue, Catra was frightened and traumatized. She let herself fall apart a few times, crumbling in

Adora's arms. There was always sadness in their closeness, the only time they were ever vulnerable like that usually surrounded some pain, even growing up. Roughhousing weirdly felt more joyful to Adora than cuddling. A part of her was hoping that could change one day. Maybe they could learn to be... gentle with each other more often?

“Why do you breathe so loudly?”

“Oh my Gods, shut up!” Adora says, laughing. “Do you even *hear* how loud you're purring?”

“Not as loud as those giant killer wasps or whatever's buzzing around out there,” Catra responds. In one motion, she tosses herself into her other side, now peering at Adora in the dark. “Seriously, I forgot how much I hate camping.”

“You're getting soft,” Adora teases.

“Sorry I'm not like the great and powerful She-Ra, who can fall asleep standing up. Maybe you have sleep apnea and that's why your breathing sounds like a woodland beast.”

“I don't know what that is but I'm sure She-Ra can heal it.” Adora feels herself relax a little more, body melting further into the soft mattress. Honestly, it feels pretty good after the day they've had. Her hands come up to rest behind her head as she rolls onto her back to stare at the ceiling until she drifts off.

“I'm serious. Something's wrong. Have you been checked out by a medic recently?” Catra doesn't sound very serious so Adora just ignores the question while she waits for whatever joke Catra's setting up.

Instead, a soft ear lands right on her chest unexpectedly. “Yeah, that doesn't sound right.”

Catra pretends to listen for another second before tsk’ing. She's right – *not* about whatever fake medical diagnosis she's making up though – she does feel warmer than usual, probably from all

the wine. Her short hair feels nice against Adora's exposed collarbone. So nice that Adora extends her arm, reaching down to pull Catra closer.

“As a trusted medical authority, you should stay and monitor me,” Adora explains right as the first yawn hits her. Her hand finds Catra's back and drifts-

Catra's *bare* back. Catra's not wearing a bra. Adora is in the same room as Catra’s boobs! Logically, she knows this is often true. But now she can’t just *un-remember* that she’s in the same room with Catra’s boobs.

A very awkward and brief glance down reveals that they’re… different now from how Adora always remembered them, petite and perky in the old cadet locker room. Not that she thinks about that often! But they’ve, uh…filled out.

“Okay, that actually *doesn't* sound good. Why's your heart freaking out?” Catra (and her boobs) push closer to Adora to theoretically investigate. “You're right,” Catra says, now yawning herself. “I think you might be defective. I’ll stay close and monitor you.”

She burrows her head further into Adora's chest and soon half of her body is draping itself across the blonde. Boobs and all.

The next yawn is coupled with a purr. Adora takes a deep breath and lets the vibration roll through her chest and into her body, distracting away from the fact that she's pretty sure that's a nipple poking her right in the side.

The weight of Catra on her…. It kinda feels like returning home to a place you actually didn't realize you missed before.

Adora switches from staring at the ceiling to counting Catra's purrs, cataloging each soft breath in and out as it ghosts across her skin. Wrapped up in the blanket and in Catra, nature quiet and calm, her eyes slip closed.

There's no guarantee of safety in this strange land but Adora trusts Catra and vice versa. And it's too tempting to not succumb to dozing off, letting relief and affection take over her body as she drifts off to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

this was a one-shot because things with me somehow start as a one-shot and then turn into 30,000 words and are clearly no longer a one-shot. the second part should be posted on catradora day.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

happy catradora day!

part two features some amazing (spicy) art from candycornsnake

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wakes up with a pounding headache. The daymoon is bright as fuck, stupid loud birds are singing. And it's hot. Like a million degrees.

This is *hell.* With her luck, she probably got poisoned last night by those hippie cult weirdos, died in her sleep, and went to one of Etheria's many hellscapes.

Isn't that just perfect? Her first real mission with the Princess Alliance and she lets her stupid nerves get her killed. Regardless of what she's sure Adora believes, Catra *was* faking being drunk. But yeah, maybe she was too convincing because her hangover is very real.

Feeling gross and dehydrated and low, she just decides to lie still and accept her punishment. Catra's spiraling thoughts of all she's done to deserve this sad fate are cut off by Adora snorting right into her ear.

"'ll get you next time," she mumbles. Then her arms tighten around Catra's waist like she's flexing.

Suddenly much more alert, Catra goes to ask just what the hell Adora thinks she's doing. But her mouth's so dry that she can *hear* her arid tongue trying to move. Sounds like sand drifting across the fucking Crimson Waste. It occurs to her to look for her bag, and therefore, her canteen, which she can just spot in the corner of the tent.

Catra's not too sure what happened last night. She was definitely in control of herself *most* of the time, but her recollection does start to get vague towards the end of the evening. That weird honey wine was good. It must have just gone straight to her head. Hopefully, she didn't make too much of a fool out of herself. Though, it's probably for the best that the creepy cult people think she's a lightweight who gets drunk easily. She and Adora might be able to use that to their advantage.

Adora finally stops flexing and her arms fall into a limp embrace. Catra's not wearing a shirt, which is weird, seeing her own bare chest hanging out while a blanket rests around her hip. But it's not quite as weird as how Adora's wrapped around her, right arm shoved between Catra and the mattress. Her tits are pressed right up against the fur on Catra's back, the dummy snoring away peacefully now that she's done sleep-boasting or whatever.

It's the first time she's woken up and Adora's still been in bed, not already having rushed off to go play hero. The first time they've slept this close since the return trip on Darla, when Adora held her through panic attacks and nightmares.

Catra takes Adora's left hand and unballs the fist so it can lay flat against her tummy. It radiates a warmth that she wishes she could feel all over her body, no matter how hot it is in this fucking sweatbox of a tent. Having Adora close, not a care in the world (except this awful fucking hangover) is really all she'd been hoping for all these weeks. With a sigh, Catra starts to purr herself back to sleep.

…Until she hears voices mumbling quietly outside the tent and Catra shoots awake again. Through the sleep fog, she remembers that's what has disturbed her in the first place, the sounds of people tiptoeing around just a couple of feet away.

The tan canvases that make up the tents are thin enough for Catra to identify two shadows. She assesses general weight, height, and the best way to leap out and get the drop on both of them at the same time. She has to be quick – Adora sleeps with a

fucking knife and from Catra's memory, she has the reflexes and awareness of a toddler in the morning. The last thing Catra needs is to be fighting off two intruders and a large, armed infant at the same time.

With no small effort, Catra slides gently out of Adora's arms and sits up. She doesn't even get to enjoy the sleepy whine she hears behind her. The two figures move closer to the tent's closure but hesitate before reaching to pull it back.

"Yoo hoo," one of them obnoxiously calls out instead. "Young lovers? There's breakfast and tea."

Catra's previously unconscious bed partner jolts up quickly. Her hand instinctively darts under the pillow. From there, it's a dizzying tussle that makes Catra regret just about everything she put into her body the night before as it threatens to make a reappearance. She launches herself at Adora, reaching simultaneously to cover her mouth and knock away the knife. It's only a 50% success rate unfortunately.

With one hand firmly over Adora's mouth, Catra only manages to futilely grab at her wrist. Adora's eyes are wide and confused, almost unseeing. The dummy's half asleep and on auto-pilot and she's still somehow stronger than Catra expected. Adora mindlessly tries to buck her off so Catra has to fully straddle her to try to get the upper-hand.

"Whhhh aaaaaa u *oOOoingg?!"* Adora shrieks right into Catra's palm.

Catra frantically nods towards the entrance but stupid Adora won't stop squirming long enough to follow. Her legs get tangled in the sheets and then she's kicking to get them *and* Catra off.

There's a hearty deep chuckle outside the tent. "Ah, morning dew…" one of them whispers way too loudly.

Adora freezes under Catra, eyes darting towards the tent door. Catra springs on the opportunity and snatches the knife away. It's

so stereotypically princess-y that Catra's almost embarrassed for Adora. Right at the top of the grip is a pretty purple gem that might as well scream, 'I stole this from Glimmer.'

Still laughing super annoyingly, the two strangers walk away quickly.

Catra keeps her hold on Adora for just a couple moments longer until she's sure that they're truly alone. And also that Adora isn't still planning to fight her.

When things are silent, just the normal sounds of the rest of the camp in the distance, Catra sits up straight, trying to lean her butt onto the heels of her feet. Except, it instead makes contact with Adora's upper thighs.

Judging by how Adora's face completely morphs from 'perplexed' to 'what fucking universe is this', they both realize that Catra is half-naked and straddled across her waist at the same time.

"Uh…" tumbles out of Catra's mouth.

Adora takes a deep breath that's supposed to calm herself but really sounds super shaky. So this clearly isn't still a dream, she figures. In her dreams of Catra, Adora is usually a lot more smooth and composed. Catra also isn't usually as stiff. In Adora's imagination, she's…pliable. Able to be moved all… *sorts of ways* …

Catra tilts her head in curiosity as she basically watches Adora go into some kind of eyes-wide-open coma.

"Oh, fuck. Did I accidentally bang your head or something?"

"Why'd you attack me?!" Adora suddenly whispers, snapping herself out of it.

"Attack you?" Catra asks with great offense. "I committed the unspeakable crime of just generally being within arm's reach of you while you were sleeping and you tried to throw a knife at me."

Adora’s lips drop into a flat line, eyes narrowed at Catra’s ridiculousness. “It’s a *dagger,* Catra. And I’d never throw it. Why would I just toss away a perfectly good weapon like that?”

“I can’t even believe that your tone is implying that *I’m* the one being absurd right now.” Catra tries to cross her arms but they sort of just land right under her tits, pushing her absolutely perfect chest (in Adora’s opinion anyway) right up and at attention.

Adora’s fingertips twitch slightly. Her hands had previously fallen carelessly to the mattress and now were practically itching to reach up to palm Catra’s ti-

“Breakfast?!” Adora blurts out of nowhere.

Catra’s barely wrapped her mind around whatever tense energy the two of them stumbled into before Adora drags her out of the tent to eat. They get dressed at least but Adora keeps rushing like she’s afraid to be alone together.

It’s actually not all that different from how she behaves around the castle. More than once, Catra's accidentally been in their room when Adora's dropped by to grab something from her desk and the dummy always jogs out quickly so they don’t have to be alone together. She's fine in common spaces but the bedroom seems like a no go.

They’re late for breakfast, though there’s still plenty of food. Heaps of eggs and smoked meat are piled on the communal table and Gin assures them that it’s okay to dig in and eat as much as they want. Clearly, they’re the last two to join since everyone else is already at work with their various tasks, the place somehow feeling both buzzing with movement and weirdly quiet and empty.

A part of Adora is a little ashamed for being lazy and sleeping in this morning. Usually, she'd be up and out by dawn. But the bed

was warm and cozy and Catra's soft fur against her skin was so soft. And the dream she'd been having, where they were fighting and it turned into…well, it suspiciously turned into where things seemed to be heading when Adora woke up. Catra on top of her. *Naked.*

Adora begins hacking up a lung next to her, so loudly that Catra has to drop all of her delicious snacks to rush to her side.

"Oh, is it too spicy?" Hess asks, appearing suddenly next to them. She's carrying a large stack of wood she's clearly chopped, judging by the layer of sweat dripping down her face. "Try a piece of bread," she suggests before jogging away at a speed that no one should be able to keep up with such a heavy load.

Catra narrows her eyes at Hess' back. Maybe Adora would be able to keep her focus on her food if everyone wasn't walking around all casually attractive and half-dressed. She practically shoves a hunk of bread into Adora's still half-open mouth.

"Stop it," Adora tries to protest. But soon Catra is wrapping her free hand around her waist and moving to guard Adora against some unseen threat.

"What is it?" she whispers, mouth still full, head swiveling to look for danger. All Adora can see is people working but Catra's tense and guarded. She probably doesn't even realize she's growling quietly.

Wood deposited in a neat pile in the center of the clearing, Hess hustles back towards the treeline for more. She makes one quick stop at the table as she passes, pulling a palm-sized bright green leaf from her pocket.

Hess hands it over to Catra, who Adora has to kick in the shin to get her to actually reach for it. "A little recovery trick. For last night," Hess says with a conspiratorial smile. "Chew on it for a couple minutes. Make sure you don't swallow it though."

She continues on without waiting for a response. As soon as Hess turns around, Adora tries to slap the leaf out of Catra's hands.

“Cut it out,” Catra hisses, pulling it out of reach. “Get your own weird poisonous leaf. Greedy.”

“I know you’re just being a contrarian. We don’t even know what it is. Just throw it out.”

“What’s making you so paranoid this morning?”

“You!” Adora whispers. Because Catra is wound so tightly. Not because Adora couldn’t get the image of Catra in bed out of her brain.

She watches as Catra does a deep visual assessment of their surroundings, ears swiveling every direction at once somehow. This is definitely *not* helping Adora feel less on edge.

“You know, I’m starting to think you were right last night,” Catra says, her voice a dramatic whisper. “Maybe I wasn’t taking this very seriously. Seeing lots of threats now. *Looootsa* threats.”

Adora shoves bread into her own mouth to distract from this. It’s so classic Catra, being over-the-top just to piss Adora off. Catra slinks down a bit in her seat as if she’s trying to hide in plain sight.

“Cut it out,” Adora mimics back at her.

“Did you make sure they tasted the food first?” Catra asks, pretending she didn’t eat half a ham before she even sat down. She tosses the leaf onto the table quickly, shaking her hand like it’s been burned.

Adora takes a deep breath and continues eating. She will not be baited into reacting.

“What about that?” Catra points across the clearing where half a dozen women are practicing some sort of synchronized

movement, hips gently tilting from side to side and arms extended to the skies.

“They're dancing. You've literally seen dancing before,” Adora points out.

“Maybe,” Catra reluctantly accepts. “But what if it's an advanced form of fighting?”

“I’m gonna show *you* an advanced form of fighting if you don’t quit it,” Adora mutters.

“That’s what they want - for us to turn against each other. They’ve been putting drugs in the water to make us act erratically. That’s why you tried to *throw a knife at me* this morning.”

“It was- ” Adora cuts herself off with a frustrated groan. No. She’s going to let Catra be incorrect and ridiculous all on her own. It hurts to let an error just sit there in the air between them when Adora could easily fix it.

She lasts less than a minute, Catra coyly smiling the whole time, waiting for Adora to break.

Finally, Adora *has* to explain, “It was a *dag-”*

This time, Catra’s squeaky laughter cuts her off. While Adora would usually be overjoyed at Catra having fun, she refuses to let it happen at her own expense. With Catra distracted with thinking how hilarious she is, Adora takes advantage and reaches to pinch her on the side, right in the fleshy part that always used to make Catra shriek. Once, Adora planned the perfect sneak attack and got Catra so good in the mess hall that she went boneless and threw her rations tray at Kyle.

Unfortunately, that was a long time ago and Catra’s really honed her senses since then. She seems to just *know* what Adora’s about to do. Her claws come out immediately so that when Catra catches the pale hand edging towards her, Adora has to not instinctively tense up for an actual fight.

“What’s with you and these old moves?” Catra taunts.

Her hand comes up quickly, en route towards Adora’s head. Probably to yank her ponytail or something, Adora imagines. Speaking of ‘old moves.’

Adora counters, grabbing at Catra’s wrist. And then they’re just tussling, each trying to slip loose or overpower the other, until they jostle themselves a bit too much and the makeshift bench under them (really just a bisected tree propped up by a few stumps) starts to tip over. Neither of them is willing to admit defeat and let go, so down they head, both following the bench’s trajectory and falling backward until they’re flat on their backs in the dirt.

Catra has the wind knocked out of her. Adora’s a godsdamn maniac. Acting wacky all morning, trying to fucking tickle her in public like a child, and now grabbing at Catra, wild-eyed and laughing?

“Give up,” she tries to say but it’s clearly taking all of her strength to keep Catra from slithering out.

Catra attempts to force air back into her lungs while Adora struggles to kick her legs free from where they’re somehow criss-crossed with Catra’s. It’s unclear when they got all tangled up in each other. They’re probably just lucky that they didn’t accidentally kick the table and take all the food down with them.

A long shadow slowly comes to loom overhead, blocking out the daymoons.

“We’re a peaceful commune, kids,” Livi says. Catra glances up briefly to see her standing over them, hands on her hips and a mocking smile on her face.

“Yeah, *peace,* Adora,” Catra grunts out, still struggling. “Maybe you should try it out.”

She successfully gets a leg free first and smartly uses it to push her foot into Adora's ribs. It should be enough leverage to get her hand back but dumb Adora opens her mouth like she's willing to resort to biting.

"Enough," Livi chastises. "Break it up or I'm sending Hess over to pry you apart."

There's authority in her voice. Adora was never good with defying authority.

She fights for a second longer before offering, "Truce?"

"Yes, you're both losers. Now fix our table and go wash up." Livi walks away without waiting to see if they actually follow through.

Adora's grip loosens but doesn't relent completely. Catra considers using this opening to enact her revenge.

But Livi's voice floats over from somewhere, unseen. "I don't repeat myself."

"On three," Adora suggests. "One-"

Catra shoves her foot further into Adora's stomach and rushes to her feet before she can be caught.

"Washing up?" she whispers, smiling down at a very red and annoyed Adora. "Maybe this is just a ploy to separate us from any weapons."

Adora tries so hard to not get wound up, even as the frustration shines clearly on her face. "Catra, we're both *walking* weapons. I think we'll be fine."

They follow Livi's directions to the bathing area, which basically just amount to walking through the trees until they hear the lapping sounds of the river.

The trail is barely there, a long path where the foliage gives way to a narrow patch of dirt. Catra assigns herself navigator, which Adora is only sorta offended by. Anyone can follow a footpath through the woods, Catra just likes to show off.

It's a reasonably short walk and when they finally come upon the Singing River, Adora's both relieved and a little disappointed. The body of water is huge and clear and it must be warm cause there's about 10 people already in it, bathing and frolicking about. But it isn't actually *singing.*

Fine. Alternate plan: ask Swifty to narrate the musical he's writing about the adventures of a traveling warrior and her horse troubadour for the entire ride home. It's actually really impressive – he's made Adora listen to the entire plot and all of the songs from beginning to end many many times in the past couple months – but it'll be sweet, hilarious torture for Catra.

"What are you giggling about?" Catra asks, being all suspicious.

"Nothing," Adora answers quickly but does a terrible job of hiding the grin on her face, imagining Catra burying her head in Adora's neck in a pitiful attempt to cover her ears.

Ako exits the water just as they arrive, water streaming off her muscles. Adora must mistake Catra looking quickly away from Ako's body as bashfulness rather than burning jealousy cause she's still sporting that shit-eating grin.

"Morning," Ako calls out with a big smile. "You're just in time. The water's perfect."

She grabs a thin white towel from a small stack lying in the grass and begins drying her hair. It leaves her whole body on display and Adora's eyes wide.

"We just ate," Catra says. "Aren't you supposed to wait before swimming or something?"

Ako shrugs. “Nonsense. Bathing in the Singing River is one of the most important rituals for the vernal equinox.”

Catra has to fight not to tense up. Rituals tend to end badly for her.

“There's extra towels. Feel free to let any of the others know if you need anything.”

“Are there other rituals we should know about today?” Adora asks. “Anything we can help with?”

Ako gives a gentle shake of her head, droplets of water falling off of her horns. “Just relax and enjoy yourselves. Feel free to explore if the spirit moves you.”

Surprisingly, Catra's the first to begin undressing. As soon as Ako wanders off, towel now tied around her waist, Catra starts shrugging out of her suit.

“You're okay with this?” Adora clarifies.

Instead of answering, Catra kicks her leg free, clothes landing in a messy pile. She tries her best to appear unbothered. All of these women have no business looking so attractive while drenched like wet rats. If she and Adora were a little clearer on what the hell they want and expect from each other, Catra imagines she'd be more chill about wading into a literal pool of beautiful bodies.

But that involves talking or even looking somewhere in the general directions of their feelings, which sends Adora into a complete panic (not that Catra herself is doing much better in that area.) So Catra will just settle for standing here naked in front of this group of women and trying to project so much confidence that no one dares to look at her pretend girlfriend.

It doesn't work. As soon as Adora's outfit is in a heap next to hers, Catra can feel multiple sets of eyes on them.

She's now faced with the horrible choice of standing there longer or jumping into the river so that they're both covered up to their shoulders.

Catra shudders suddenly. It's a perfect excuse for Adora to look up at her face and not where her eyes had been drifting to before, much *much* lower. With some pride, Adora notes that she's doing a very good job of acting like she's built a slight immunity to the reappearance of Catra's boobs.

It helps to focus on the water. Catra never liked water growing up, though the Fright Zone showers were rusty and smelled like chemical waste, nothing like the calm, clear blue Singing River. During the mandated cadet showers, she usually hid in the vents in the locker room until no one was around; when necessary, she wasn't above intimidating Kyle into lying to Shadow Weaver or their Force Captain about Catra's hygiene routine. She'd been even more skittish about water since the war but a couple trips to Mystacor with Glimmer, Scorpia, and Mermista had seemed to temper that a little.

"You sure you're okay with this?" Adora asks again because she was too busy watching Catra whip off her clothes to catch if she actually got a response.

Shyly, without looking at her, Catra reaches for Adora's hand for support, ears flat against her head. Adora finds a patch of muddy grass that dips low before it trails into the water and she confidently leads them both into the river until it's up to their necks. Ako's right - the water is perfect. Just cool enough to be refreshing. Everyone around them floats serenely, seemingly not at all concerned about whatever's happening tonight. Everyone except Catra, of course. Her pretend paranoia has definitely circled back around to actual paranoia. Her eyes are narrowed to slits, swiveling from person to person while she looks absolutely miserable.

Adora begins treading water closer, letting her hands gently rest on Catra's waist for reassurance. Catra remains tense but she

doesn’t complain as her fingers quickly grip onto Adora’s shoulders for support.

There's something about the repetitive sound of the water sloshing back and forth that manages to calm Adora's nerves. Some of the tension melts out of her overused muscles. It's not possible to do much actual bathing with Catra still using her as a human flotation device but Adora finds that she doesn't mind.

After several minutes of just silently swimming, Catra's claws finally retract, though her hold on Adora doesn't. (Just another thing that Adora finds she doesn't mind.)

Apparently everyone else reads Catra as not an immediate threat finally because they start to come closer one-by-one or in small groups and make idle conversation with Adora and Catra.

One – Qana, Adora remembers, a friendly woman about their age with walnut-colored skin and curly pink hair – gently asks about their relationship, which Adora has to handle answering since Catra seems incapable of swimming and speaking at the same time. How long they’ve known each other (“we grew up together”), how long they’ve been a couple (“a couple months now?” Adora says unsurely), how open they are.

“What? What’s that mean?” Adora asks.

“Oh,” Qana replies with a smile. “Nevermind, friends. No need to worry. We accept all here.”

She politely gives a slight wave before swimming away to speak to someone else.

“We-uh-we’re not open, right?” Catra asks quietly, well aware of Qana sharing this new discovery with Cay, a pale thin girl who not-so-subtly quickly stops checking them out.

“Open for what?” Adora's eyes shoot around before she leans in way too close to whisper, “Is that cult lingo?”

“Oh, I thought you were faking. You really don’t know anything about how relationships work.”

“Stop pretending you know everything about relationships,” Adora says with a good-natured shake of her head. “You’re as clueless as I am. And I *know* you steal my books, Catra. You never put them back the way you found them.”

“You have a *shocking* amount of porn,” Catra casually shoots back.

Adora knows she’s blushing but powers through anyway. “It’s not porn, it’s *romance*. And I’ve seen the search history on your tracker pad so you can’t judge.”

“Yeah, that’s not romance. That’s just porn.” Catra laughs at Adora's suddenly shy face. “She was asking if she could join us, princess.”

“Well, she was swimming with us. That was fine.”

Catra blinks once, *very* slowly. “...in bed.”

Adora’s eyes widen, which is good. For a minute, Catra thought she might have to explain that she didn’t mean *sleeping*.

“Uh...do you…?”

Catra’s surer about the answer than she is about the exact question being asked of her. “No. Do you?” Adora shakes her head, still looking a little shell-shocked. “Okay. So…”

“Not open,” Adora finishes, before turning to lift herself out of the water.

Apparently they're done here, which is just fine with Catra. The pads of her fingers were starting to get that weird wrinkly feeling. Adora had chilled out minutely but Catra was still a long way from ever feeling that comfortable submerged in water.

As soon as she's on dry land, Adora reaches a hand down to help Catra up. Catra has to ignore the floaty feeling her stomach gets watching Adora's bare body as she flexes with exertion. And then again when Adora doesn't step back so she and Catra end up standing just a couple inches away, both seemingly holding their breath while they wait for the other's next move.

"I don't think these towels are gonna be good enough," Adora says randomly. As if to prove her point, Adora trails a finger down Catra's hip bone, probably ignoring the way she gasps quietly. "You're soaked."

Catra sorta swallows a laugh, which is confusing. Adora's pretty sure she didn't make a joke. So instead, she keeps her hold on Catra's hand. With her other, Adora does a messy job of laying their towels on the grass, right in a nice daymoon beam that's breaking through the peaks of the mountain.

That's how they whittle away most of the morning, Catra napping in the warm rays as they slowly dry her fur, pretending that she can't feel Adora's eyes watching her. Or the ghost of a touch occasionally against her thigh. The third or fourth time that happens, Catra's tail wraps around Adora's wrist, keeping her there.

Adora tries not to jolt when she's caught. She's not sure if Catra's still asleep and this is an unconscious move, like the way she reaches out in the middle of the night. Adora had rationalized her wandering hand as just checking to see if Catra was dry yet. But she lets it rest there, getting comfortable until her fingers drift to the inside of Catra's leg. When she hears a sleepy sigh next to her, Adora smiles, relaxing on her back in the nude, just watching the clouds drift by overhead while she listens to the light lapping of the river and the quiet breathing of her favorite person in the galaxy.

Ako said that they could explore and that seems like a good enough excuse to do some snooping around.

"I can create a distraction," Adora offers once she's dressed. At least they're on the same page about how stealth isn't her strong suit.

Unfortunately, Adora seems to think she's best suited for *leadership* of all things. Like Catra wasn't second-in-command of an entire fucking arm-Catra figures it's probably best not to mention that as her qualification for why she should come up with a plan. Adora likely wouldn't stick to it anyway.

So they end up pretending to nonchalantly wander around the camp. People are working harder than yesterday, building what appears to be a huge bonfire, practicing dancing and drumming until Catra's sure that her ears are gonna bleed from hearing the same beats and wordless chants over and over again. A number of people are napping, according to Cay.

"Saving up their energy for later, ya know?" she says with a conspiratorial grin.

No, Catra absolutely does *not know* what these idiots are up to. Adora leaps at the chance to ask for more info, only to be told once again that she'll understand everything later. It's fucking infuriating.

"I bet there's answers in Eras' tent," Adora suggests quietly.

Catra would kinda prefer not going anywhere near wherever Eras sleeps and/or keeps her secrets. The universe has been trying to teach her not to go poking her nose into things for years and, for once, she's gonna actually listen to that lesson.

That's not good enough for Adora though. "Asking around isn't getting us anywhere. No one's gonna give us a straight answer."

Every time they try to breach the subject of Eras with anyone, all they get in return is a declaration of love for Eras. Love for each other. Love for love blah blah blah.

When Taff pauses in filling up bottles of wine from a cask – like *so many* bottles of wine, what the hell do they think they'll be doing tonight? – to repeat the same nonsense they've heard from everyone else, Catra finally snaps. She turns to Adora who's already looking at her expectantly.

Catra shakes her head slightly. There must be someone here who will plainly explain literally anything that's happening.

Livi. She's got enough barely contained rage that Catra can probably annoy her into accidentally giving away something. Wordlessly, Catra begins leading Adora in the general direction she last saw Livi, hovering near the tents while she was collecting supplies of some kind.

There's a corner further on the opposite end of where they placed Catra and Adora, and Catra can just barely make out Livi's voice speaking quietly.

Catra reaches back to take Adora's hand. She doesn't really know why. This won't sell the idea of them being a boring harmless couple but who cares. As they edge closer, Catra curses internally – Adora's heavy boots are crunching on grass and random branches so loudly that there's no way Livi won't hear them coming.

But she must be too wrapped up in her conversation to notice cause Livi just continues on, "We better keep an eye on the smaller one. If anyone goes near Adora, she looks like she'll put up a hell of a fight. I don't know about you but I like my face intact, thanks."

Pride swells in Catra's chest. She's glad that it's completely apparent to everyone that Adora and Catra belong to each other and she's not above attacking anyone to prove it. Then, just as quickly, Catra feels a pang of guilt. She's trying to work on that – the whole 'attacking for no good reason' part of her instincts.

Actually, no, this is totally fine. These cult creeps are plotting to harm her and Adora. This is one of the only times that Perfuma would approve of Catra fighting first and then pausing to ask about everyone's feelings later.

The other person scoffs. Catra realizes it's Qana or whoever, from earlier. "She's possessive. She's clearly just insecure about their love. She'll grow out of it."

Catra can feel her fur bristling in response. With a sharp tug, she drags Adora around the corner of a tent so she can get a closer look and totally not because she's considering leaving someone's faces *not* intact.

She spots Livi and Qana quietly laughing to themselves – about her, she grumbles internally – while exiting a particularly large tent, their arms heavy with blankets and fur rugs. When they begin to walk away, Catra pushes her and Adora back into the shadows of the daymoon, hiding as best they can in clear view.

"What did you hear?" Adora asks.

"Nothing," Catra says quickly. "Fine. Be distracting. Make a complete fool of yourself. That should be easy enough for you," Catra mutters before slinking away.

Adora gets that challenging look in her eyes, seconds away from arguing before she realizes she's getting exactly what she wanted. She disappears around the corner and it isn't long before Catra can hear her loudly offering to demonstrate how much wood she can hold at once.

Of course Adora's idea of a distraction involves her showing off for everyone. She couldn't just start a contained fire like a normal person.

Now thoroughly annoyed at everyone, and feeling pretty ridiculous about it deep down, Catra slips into the open tent. It's clearly Eras' – everything is the height of luxury. Or as much luxury as you can have sleeping on the ground and living off other people's

labor. The bed looks big enough to hold 4 or 5 people. There are books and scrolls. A *desk.* This isn't just some temporary thing for her. How long have these people been out here? How long has Glimmer known about this?

There's no time to go through so much writing so Catra nixes that immediately. Really, the most out of place thing in the room is a very large, ancient-looking chest shoved into the corner next to the writing desk. It's all weathered but well-preserved leather and silver, sealed closed with a hefty padlock. Nothing that Catra couldn't bypass with her claws in a couple of short minutes.

Turns out she doesn't have a couple minutes. Catra's bent over the chest, listening closely for the tell-tell tick of the inside mechanism shifting, which is basically impossible to hear since Adora's got half the camp cheering her on somewhere. She can't make out anything over the sound of Adora's name being chanted until there's a distinct footstep right behind her.

There's no way to play this off. 'Oh, we're actually just bandits?' crosses her mind.

Catra whips around quickly, claws still out just in case. She's full of adrenaline already, prepared for Eras to drop the chill, generous leader facade and reveal her true plan. Punish Catra for trespassing. Lock her in the trunk and drop her in the Singing River.

Her fur doesn't stand up, Catra notices absently. The unasked question lingering there is quickly answered when Hess steps into the tent instead of Eras. She gives a long look at Catra, the chest, and the rest of the untouched space.

Then her face breaks out into a shy, embarrassed grin. It kinda reminds Catra of Scorpia, just a big goofy lug.

"Guess you caught me," Hess says for some bizarre reason.

"I did?" Catra asks tentatively.

“I wanted to grab a couple of things out of there,” she motions with her head towards the chest. “Make sure tonight was special. I see you had the same idea.”

“It’s locked,” is all Catra can really think to say.

“Shoot!” Hess whispers to herself. “Guess we’ll both have to wait until later.”

Catra nods, trying to hide the tension in her body as best she can. No need to put someone this large on the defensive for no reason. But when she fails to make another move, Hess’s friendly grin begins to slip.

“I bet you’re curious,” she says. Catra shrugs noncommittally. “Don’t worry. Everything’ll be revealed tonight at the ceremony.”

Her voice is kinder than Eras’ ominous warning from the night before that just barely penetrated Catra’s wine haze. It’s no less creepy though.

“Come on,” Hess urges. “Adora’s invented the most fun game!”

“I’m fine,” Adora insists again. And she is. She always prefers to have strategy conversations while tucked into a ball, clutching her arms gently. Catra should know that.

“You lifted too many logs and now if there’s a fight, you won’t be able to defend yourself. I’m gonna have to take care of you again.”

Adora chooses to ignore that Catra is also in bed with her, sprawled out on her back and chugging water. The hangover has really started to catch up with her and it’s too late to ask Hess for another weird leaf to fix it.

Everyone assumed that they’d need a nap after such an exciting day. A couple of people had even accused them of trying to get an

early start on the night's festivities, winking and grinning at some joke neither of them still understands.

Adora lifts her head lightly and angles closer to Catra. Without saying anything, the trajectory of the canteen moves past Catra's mouth and to Adora's lips.

She gets her fill, grunting out her thanks before collapsing back onto the bed.

"I can still take Hess and Ako if needed," Adora says.

Catra continues to keep one eye on the door of their tent. She swears they're being listened to but no one seems to be hovering out there. Not one person in this whole set-up seems to have good enough ears to pull off listening from afar. But…they must be watching them. There's a feeling in the pit of her gut that she can't shake.

"I don't think those two have thrown a punch in their whole lives," Catra argues. "If shit goes down, you focus on Eras."

"And what'll you be doing?"

"I'll take on everyone else," Catra answers, like that's obvious. "I'm giving you the easy one."

"Oh, thanks," Adora says sarcastically. "And how do you plan on fighting 20 people at once?"

"I don't know," Catra grumbles back. "If I douse our only light source to confuse them, how well can you see in the dark?"

"Well, I *glow* so that's not going to be very effective."

Catra takes a long sip of water. "Good point."

"Should we just slip out? We can come back later with backup."

“You wanna start being smart now? Shoulda thought about that before you were showing off to everyone.”

With great effort, Adora lifts her head again to glance up at Catra’s face. Her head’s resting on a stack of pillows so that she doesn’t have to worry about spilling water all over herself while she sulks. Catra’s brow is knitted together and she’s about one second from snarling, deep in thought.

“Are you jealous?” Adora asks. She barely has enough energy to tease yet she’s sure she’s successful when Catra hisses at her. It’s the non-threatening one, not the one that actually means you’ve got about 5 seconds to get out of Catra’s space.

So Adora uses the last of her muscle control to grin.

“Swing your stupid arms wherever you want. I don’t care,” Catra argues.

She had maybe been politely asked not to actively support any rebuilding efforts where She-Ra was present. Catra’s hissing and barely restrained anger had scared off lots of local villagers who were just innocently attempting to thank She-Ra for her help, much to Adora's smug amusement. After that, Glimmer decided that Catra was most helpful back in Bright Moon. Glimmer was probably starting to regret that.

“Just kinda seems like you care,” Adora mumbles, unable to tamp down her smile. “Catra!” she pretends to gasp. “Do you *care* about me?”

Catra continues to sulk. “Actually, I’ll take out Eras. Good luck fighting a camp full of zealots without using your hands.”

“I’m not above biting my way out of a situation,” Adora admits. “I feel like you might *care* about me putting my mouth on everyone though.”

Still cradled in a ball, Adora doesn’t have her full range of motion. That’s her perfectly legitimate excuse for not catching how quickly

Catra abandons her canteen and pounces, poking mercilessly at Adora's sore biceps.

"Noooo, my arms!"

When Ako enters to retrieve them, she finds them on the floor of the tent. To rest up for the night, Adora's *chosen* not to use her arms, making her an easy target. She's face-down trying to protect her vulnerable muscles with Catra's knees digging into her upper back. Adora makes a valiant effort at trying to bite her way out, nipping at Catra's calves and occasionally her tail as it swoops back and forth.

Just over her wild giggling, Adora can hear Ako announce, "Sorry to interrupt…this? But it's time."

Ako leads them to the center of camp with an easy, confident stride. She's excited but holding it in well.

Adora wishes she could feel as sure. They were in such a hurry that she forgot to even shove a dagger in her shoe. Beside her, Catra's affecting a cool posture but Adora can see the cracks. The unsure movement of her tail. That hectic energy she has right before a fight.

It seems like everyone is already there and has started without them. The drummers, pounding their hands in unison against the stretched leather, probably haven't even stopped since this morning. Same with the dancers, still twirling their hips, lost in the beat. Everyone else is eating from the communal table, drinking, or locked in conversation.

The 5 night moons are high in the sky, providing the only light besides the bonfire that's nearly as tall as Adora is. She doesn't even realize that they've all circled it until Ako leaves her and Catra in a spot and fills in the remaining gap next to them. Qana and Cay are on Catra's right. There's other familiar faces from the past two days that she can just barely make out over the fire.

The only missing piece is Eras.

“Dance,” Ako says, more of an invitation than an order.

When Catra looks reluctant to join in, Qana giggles, swaying in Cay’s arms to the rhythm. “Come on. It’s fun.”

Right. They’re supposed to blend in. Adora reaches for Catra’s hands and is only a little surprised when she’s allowed to hold onto them gently. They fall into step, half-hearted rocking from side to side with each other. This isn’t the perfectly timed (and weirdly charged) choreography that Catra baited her into at Frosta’s Princess Prom. This is much closer to the wild dancing that followed the defeat of Prime; when the meager camp they’d set up had suddenly exploded with people, cheering and partying and celebrating their victory. No longer in She-Ra form, Adora had gotten a bit of anonymity that first night. She and Catra had the freedom to hug and cry and twirl each other around until they collapsed in the grass. No war, no rulers, no authority figures, no strict adherence to proper protocol. Just two doofs trying to figure out how to move their limbs together in tandem after a lifetime of restraint.

“What are you thinking about?” Catra asks.

“The last time we danced.”

Catra laughs quietly. “You only fell over like a dozen times. Try not to repeat that, okay?”

For revenge, Adora tugs her hands until Catra’s only a breath away. She delights in the shock in Catra’s face before moving to wrap her arms around Catra’s shoulders.

“You lead then,” Adora says with a challenge in her voice.

“I *was,”* Catra replies. The fire nearby really highlights the spark of mischief in her eyes. “Try to keep up, princess.”

Adora makes up her mind to focus on how Catra’s freckles look under the flickering light, rather than the feel of claws teasing at her waist as she moves even closer.

Catra moves fluidly, which isn't much of a surprise. Like the last time they danced, she puts on a show, her whole body in perfect sync, that's so effortless and hypnotizing that Adora can't imagine all eyes aren't on her immediately.

The lack of Eras’ presence is both concerning and a small weight off of Catra's chest. As much as she's worried about what Eras might be up to, it's nice to relax for a moment and try to enjoy the sight of Adora absolutely not understanding that you're supposed to flow with the beat, not wrestle it into submission.

“Do you even *know* what hips are for?”

For a long moment, Adora looks too dazed to even respond. Her head is tilted towards Catra's face but her eyes keep drifting downwards. At first, it seems like she's trying to focus on the steps. But her gaze doesn't seem to reach that low, instead stopping right around where Catra's busy trying to pull off some sort of churning motion with hips that she saw the dancers doing earlier. She's pretty sure hers looks better and, if Adora's tongue hanging out of her mouth is any indication, Catra's right.

There's something about the act of Adora looking at her, *really* focusing on her, that makes Catra's stomach clench in a way that she's shocked to find isn't *un* enjoyable. Just…kinda embarrassing. Exposed, maybe? Across years and bunks and locker rooms and battlefields, it's what she's always wanted. To be seen by Adora. To be taken in, understood.

“You stopped moving,” she points out.

The moons are high in the dark sky and the stars are shining brightly. So when Adora blushes all the way to her ears before making eye contact again, it's hard to miss.

Call it growth or something but for once, Catra doesn't tease her. Instead, she closes her eyes, tilts her head back, and delights in the feeling of Adora's open appreciation.

With the rush of adrenaline from waiting for whatever these weirdos are planning next and knowing Adora can't seem to look away, Catra feels like she could dance for hours.

The slow chant of 'Eras!' that starts up around her dashes that hope.

"Eras! Eras!" people begin calling out. It's low at first, a murmur before building to a…moan?

Catra's eyes shoot open. Near the table, women are pouring wine down each other's throats. Eating fruit out of one another's mouths.

Closer to the fire, people have apparently started to get warm because most of them are suddenly nude or half-way there, stepping out of their clothes where they stand and leaving them in a pile on the grass next to them.

The drums, Catra notices, trying to distract herself from yet another appearance off too many naked attractive people, speed up. What had been more of a smoldering slow beat is turning faster and louder, echoing the sound of her own rushing heartbeat in her ears.

The air feels tense and warm. As tight as the leather on the drum, resounding over and over again. The chorus of "Eras" carries over the music.

Couples continue to sway together though Catra's come to a complete stop. There's no way they're blending in now – a quick look at Adora confirms this as the blonde observes the group as if she just got dropped on a foreign planet for the first time.

Around the circle, hands begin to wander. Dancing turns to bare bodies pressed closely together, everyone pleading for Eras in one

voice, low and needy.

Catra'd thought they never got a clear answer to what the cult of Eras *wanted.* But maybe it's been there all along. They'd been answering honestly – each other. Love.

'Oh, Gods. It's a…'

"Sex cult," Catra whispers. Is that a thing?

She feels a little light-headed. She's had this dream before, she thinks. Where a literal pile of women is about to have sex right in front of her and she's stuck in place while they whisk Adora off.

Maybe that counts as a nightmare?

Next to her, Adora gives a goofy laugh, sounding like that dumb horse of hers.

"A sex cult? Catra, don't be silly. They're probably just going to do another ritual bath or somethi-"

She's cut off by a few people cheering as Cay grips Qana's hair harshly, nearly bending her over backwards as she licks a long stripe from her exposed nipple to her neck. Adora swallows her words with a whimper. Her throat is suddenly tight and it feels like her tongue is about 4 sizes too big for her mouth.

'Oh my Gods, stop thinking about tongues!', her brain shouts in a panic.

"Sez khulth," Adora mumbles.

"You're turning blue," Catra whispers. "Take a fucking breath. We're supposed to be blending in."

That thought makes Adora's eyes go wide. She glances at herself, fully clothed, at the group of women, all of whom have disrobed, and then at Catra, who looks like she'd rather gnaw her own arm off than join them.

“Stop scowling,” Adora says quietly back. “You look disgusted.”

“I’m not! Just...strategizing. Someone’s gotta get us out of this and you’re clearly hopeless.”

“No need to be worried, my beloveds,” Eras’ voice rings out close to them in the dark.

Catra feels herself tense as Eras emerges from the shadows. She's moving towards the group, dressed in an even shorter piece of cloth than last night, this one a luxurious gold silk that barely covers any of her supple-looking skin.

With a mysterious smile, Eras shoots a wink at Catra and Adora. “Just relax.”

“Your goddess has arrived,” Eras loudly announces as she moves closer to the center. The drums quiet to just a rumble in the background.

Catra's brain lurches at the title. *Goddess.* Silhouetted against the fire, Eras looks larger than life. The thought that they might be up against a god, the blind allegiance of these people, the *fucking orgy* – it's all almost too overwhelming to take in at once.

“I see you all started without me,” Eras teases. There’s a few chuckles among the group. “Tonight, we celebrate the vernal equinox. A time of alignment. For coming together as one. A time of rebirth. Of rejoicing. A time for love. And *pleasure,”* she purrs.

The word is met with raucous cheers from all, the drums sounding out a final frantic beat until they're suddenly silent.

Catra and Adora watch in stunned silence as the dancers and drummers join the fray and people begin to couple off. Well, *mostly* couple. Catra definitely catches a few small pods of multiple folks but looks away as she gets lost in the logistics of how that could work.

'This is the endgame?', Adora wonders. In her rare free time, she'd always enjoyed reading. She'd already been through several of the materials on ancient Etherian history that George and Lance had collected. There were many many gods and goddesses who had been worshipped over time – including a god of *masks* for some reason – but she couldn't remember a single reference to Eras. Yet deities seemed to generally be fickle, horny creatures so one dedicating herself to being the god of orgies didn't feel that unusual.

Eras slowly circles the group, gracing most of them with an encouraging smile while they start absolutely going wild on each other. Out of the corner of her eye, Adora can see Catra watching Eras anxiously. Adora, on the other hand, accidentally catches a glimpse of Livi bending Hess over and decides this is a great night to do some impromptu stargazing.

Too quickly, Eras drifts back over to them. She leans down closer, still towering over the two, both feeling tiny in her presence.

"Come join me in my tent," Eras instructs quietly, before walking away without waiting for a response. "Just to talk," she throws over her shoulder with a wry smile.

Neither of them touches the glass of wine Eras offers. This is certainly not the night for dulled senses. They also don't sit as she'd suggested. Adora tries to relax her posture, remembering Catra's suggestion from yesterday, but it's hard not to recoil as Eras opens her arms wide.

"I want you both to feel accepted and welcomed here," she tells them. "Embraced. *Held."*

Catra's lashing tail accidentally slaps across the back of Adora's thigh.

Eras gently drops her arms. "You are not required to take part in anything tonight. But if you choose to indulge, we have some

values you must always remember. Consent. Pleasure. Communication. Openness.”

Catra tries to get a stealthy look around, interested in just how ‘open’ Eras intends to be about her secret plan. (Because there *has* to be a secret plan here, she's sure of it. A nagging thought in the back of her head disagrees loudly but Catra stuffs that down. There's a mission to focus on here… probably.)

There’s not much in the tent that’s different than earlier. Nothing that Eras looks to have been working on while she was missing from the ceremony. Same lush bed, lots of pillows, papers in the same order. And then her eyes land on the chest, open and fully in plain view. It’s chock full of ropes and whips and chains. Instruments of torture, Catra thinks, proud of herself for correctly assessing that there’s still clearly some danger here.

Until she recognizes what else is inside.

Adora follows Catra's line of vision, noticing the chest. Hopefully it might have some clue about what's going on here. That hope gets extinguished when she realizes that it's just full of items that she's read about in her romance books.

Eras chuckles softly and Adora imagines that she’ll probably just be permanently beet-red for the rest of the night. “Don't be embarrassed. I'm certainly not. If something interests you, feel free to borrow it.”

“I don’t think we’ll be needing your used dildos, thanks,” Catra sasses.

Eras just takes that in stride, shrugging it off.

“I can tell that you two only have eyes for each other,” she says. Adora ducks at her head, feeling exposed, while Catra looks away, tail flickering back and forth. “But I can also tell that you have not yet been fully intimate. There is no pressure here. Do what feels natural. Learn about yourselves, your boundaries, and each other’s.”

Then almost as an afterthought, Eras tacks on, "There's *lube* by the feast table if you need it."

Not too gently, she thrusts the two out of her tent, proudly strutting back out towards a group of limbs that have wasted literally no fucking time.

"So," Adora begins. She was always the braver, Catra figures.

Unfortunately, that's as far as Adora makes it.

"We, uh,...." Catra picks up, with no plans to complete that sentence this millenia.

"We pretend?" Adora asks.

"Pretend?" Catra repeats. Maybe Adora's not familiar with the meaning of the word. Maybe she thinks it's a synonym for 'run' or something more sensible.

"Yeah. We just find a dark corner and move around a bit. On top of each other." She gulps loudly enough for probably anyone on this side of the forest to hear it. "Naked."

"Dummy," Catra hisses. "We don't have to do this just cause some fake God said we have to."

"No, I want to!" Adora yells too quickly. "For the, uh, for the mission. Right?"

"I'm pretty sure there's nothing *evil* going on here. Sparkles just didn't have enough intel." Or she *did.* Catra will definitely be having words with their queen about this when she returns.

"Uh huh," Adora responds, a bit distracted. It's harder for her to see in the dark than Catra but she's already started trying to find a quiet, unoccupied corner. Grabbing Catra's hand, she begins dragging her off to a spot further away from the fire, a bit closer to the surrounding trees and the river.

As soon as they get there, Adora stops and reaches for the lapel of Catra's jacket. The latter's still trying to catch up to exactly what's happening here. Adora seems to want to do *something.* So Catra's down for literally anything as long as her hands are the only ones on Adora's body.

She's waited long enough and she's never been good at sharing.

Adora reaches in and helps shrug the jacket off of Catra's shoulders. It barely hits the ground before her hands are on the zipper on the back of the jumper. Catra half-expects Adora to let her get herself out of it but once she unzips it, the princess hastily pulls it down. Her fingertips lightly graze Catra's hips as she drags her underwear down as well. For a fleeting second, Adora's breath ghosts across stomach and between her legs but she pops back up quickly and waits for Catra to step out of the suit.

Adora doesn't wait to remove her own jumper. She's only a little shocked when she feels claws tuck under the bottom of her sportsbra and raise it as she's kicking the suit off.

As soon as that's gone, she's surprised by Catra grabbing her roughly by the neck and pulling her down onto the ground. With an 'oof', they land awkwardly, Catra splayed out underneath her. Naked. Looking as panicked as she is pleased with herself.

"Catra! We're not gonna do it in the dirt," Adora insists. Maybe she should have mapped this out better. There's probably still time to go grab a couple things from their tent but it's hard to concentrate on that when Catra's bare body is touching hers.

"There's all this lush Etherian grass that we have She-Ra to thank for. It's softer than our old bed."

"Let me get a blanket," Adora begs, fighting to stay focused and not glance down. "I want you to be comfortable. Please."

"I'm always comfortable with you," Catra replies. The truth of that is so cutting that she has to look away from Adora just to get it out.

Obviously, that's true for Adora as well. And the grass *is* soft, she can confirm after months of collapsing into it for a quick nap during some particularly strenuous rebuilding tasks. She-Ra isn't truly the cause of it – Etheria's just naturally such a wondrous place without its magic being contained – but it's nice that Catra is pretending to appreciate something about the warrior after all this time.

"Okay," Adora accepts with a quick nod. She pauses to take a deep breath, prepare for all this 'blending in.' "I'm just gonna-"

"Kiss," falls from Catra's lips.

"What?" That honestly hadn't even occurred to Adora.

"We should probably start by kissing. That's less, uh... *intimate,"* Catra says. And, oh boy, for a word that always sounded clinical to Adora's ears, it's somehow very appealing coming from Catra. "Maybe we can just do that and roll around a bit. Plus, we already know how to kiss."

Adora pulls back to look at her more closely. Yeah, they know how to kiss. They just haven't done it since the Heart. Kinda hard to feel comfortable kissing again when the first time is with a near-corpse, Adora had imagined. She had felt bad making Catra relive such a traumatic experience and had decided to wait until the girl was ready to initiate.

Catra, for her part, just assumed since kissing wasn't needed to save a life-threatening mission, it was officially off the table. Adora had never tried it again, had never commented on it. At first, they'd hold hands or cuddle and then that just dried away as they both got busy rebuilding Etheria. That was fine. That was how Catra had always loved Adora, like a thing that you could watch from far away but would never be able to touch.

Here and now, however, kissing *is* the mission. Interesting how that worked out. Catra's starting to get the idea that this was all

very intentional, a thinly-veiled ruse cooked up by a meddling trio who was tired of dealing with her and Adora's mess.

"Yeah, okay," Adora easily agrees. Then Catra has to watch as she eagerly licks her lips in the most awkward teenaged fashion.

Catra figures it's polite to do the same.

Adora shifts so her elbows are in the dirt on either side of Catra's head. It's nice to think of doing this while there's no urgency. Maybe she'll actually get to just savor it this time.

Since Adora's on top, she elects herself to make the first move. She angles her head, drawing closer to Catra slowly. It's important to give Catra plenty of time, just in case she decides to change her mind. Instead, Catra huffs quietly before reaching her hands up to grab Adora's face and yank her closer quickly.

Their lips are touching before either seems to be adequately prepared for that. Adora doesn't move for a long second, mouth closed, just pressed gently against Catra's. She even forgets that you're supposed to close your eyes until she's watching Catra's brow furrow and has to wonder what's wrong.

Catra uses her hold on Adora's hair to angle her further, parting her lips to deepen the kiss. The feeling of her lips, so soft and plump, is heavenly. Adora doesn't even notice herself finally relaxing, her eyes falling shut, her arms going limp until she melts into Catra, kissing back in earnest.

Eras had suggested doing what feels natural multiple times. While Adora still isn't sold on her judgement, her hands move underneath Catra to grip at her back tightly and Adora isn't about to stop them. Not when Catra's sighing into her mouth. Not when Catra's legs are moving to wrap around her waist. Not when Adora bites down lightly on Catra's lip and is rewarded with a moan that she's only ever dreamed of.

This kiss is so different from their first one that it's hard to believe that was even this same lifetime. Where they were loving and sad

and overjoyed and frantic that first time, this go-around everything feels hot and needy and unhurried. Catra had always wondered who would take the lead between them, with Adora perpetually convinced she should be in charge of everything and Catra an absolute menace anytime anyone gives her an order. But it's fun to let Adora think she's calling the shots here while Catra moves her head just right and sets the pace.

Adora's surprisingly adept at making out. She's told Catra she's a 'scholar' though, in the dumbest made-up fancy voice. Apparently, that just means she's actually paid attention to the details in all of those cheesy dirty books she reads when traveling between kingdoms. For the first time, Catra can appreciate her commitment to her studies, her stomach full of flutters as she can feel herself getting more and more turned on.

In the back of her mind, Catra knows they *might* still be in danger. It's just hard to care right this very second. Every time her head clears enough to remember where they are, another wave of horniness drags her back under. Adora's muscles are firm and unyielding as her body flanks Catra's and keeps her pinned to the ground. Even when she pulls apart for air, Adora's lips are kissing her all over her face. So fucking corny and cute.

Gods, when has Catra ever called anything 'cute'? Maybe they *are* under some type of spell.

The energy feels like it's shifting. Between her and Adora, yes, but also all around them. If Catra's honest, she's wanted Adora even before she fully understood what the feeling was, this secret innermost need that never made sense until Lonnie passed her some contraband from older cadets that showed two women in a move that she's pretty sure she saw Livi and Hess pulling earlier. Yet, Catra's never wanted Adora *this much*, like it would take another jump into the Singing River just to calm down.

If Adora stops touching her, Catra might scream. If Adora *keeps* touching her, she's sure she'll scream. Catra wants to drown in all

things Adora right now and it's a scary but not totally unwelcome feeling.

Around them, it feels like people are getting more intense, the chorus of moaning and skin against skin growing louder.

"Do you feel that?" Catra finally pulls away to ask breathlessly.

Adora's eyes are glazed over, lips red and slightly swollen already. It takes her a long moment to even acknowledge that Catra just spoke. She glances down between their bodies sheepishly. "Sorry. I got a little carried away."

Confused, Catra follows her line of vision. The blonde is focused on where their legs are. Particularly, where Catra's has somehow ended up pressed right between Adora's thighs. And how it's suddenly wet down there.

"Oh, fuck," Catra whispers in awe, more than a little proud of herself for soliciting that reaction.

Adora's already tangling her fingers into Catra's short hair to pull her back in for another kiss.

"Wait, hold on a minute." Catra reaches up and holds onto Adora's face, just so she knows this isn't a rejection. Just a….brief pause maybe? "I don't know if I'm crazy but I think Eras has some kind of power. Almost like she's directing everyone to do this. Don't you feel different?"

"I mean, I feel-" Adora pauses. 'Horny' is what she feels. 'Uncontrollably hungry for Catra' is definitely what she feels. But really, that's not too different from how she always feels whenever she has a moment to let her mind drift. She wants Catra in a way that she's never wanted anyone. Having her best friend under her like this, touching her like this, is pretty much the only thing in the universe that Adora truly *wants* down to her core.

"I feel something," Adora finally agrees. "I don't think it's from Eras, though." She glances over to the woman. "Actually, I think

she’s too busy to be directing *anyone* right now.”

Catra’s eyes almost bug out of her fucking head as she takes the scene in. Amidst the groups of women absolutely going to town on each other, but, uh, surprisingly lovingly, Eras is sandwiched between Gin and Ako, face wrenched in pleasure while they each….

“Okay, fine,” Catra sighs, quickly turning back to Adora. “Maybe you’re right. I just feel….different.” Maybe it’s because they went from barely touching to suddenly doing…whatever it is they’re doing.

“I don’t think she’s a God,” Adora continues. “Just a charismatic person who really likes getting fucked.”

“Adora!” Catra pretends to gasp. “Not very becoming of a princess to use scandalous words like that.”

“I know sex words,” Adora says smugly.

“What a sad thing to be proud of.”

Ignoring her, Adora continues, “I know about tits. And pussies.” She’s not gonna mention that she’s never actually said either of these phrases out loud before.

“Oh, do you now?”

Adora falters, laughing nervously. “A little.”

“Yeah? Prove it,” Catra challenges. She lifts her hips up slightly just once, hinting.

“I thought we were just pretending,” Adora says but she's already moving her right hand from Catra's back to her collarbone. It rests there lightly, just letting them both test out Adora's warm palm on her fur.

“Right. Pretending,” Catra manages to say. Her mouth feels dry again, reminding her of how she woke up in Adora's arms.

“Unless you...don't want to pretend?” Adora tries. Catra's eyes are half-open, the black parts so wide that you can barely make out any color. Never once has she looked at Adora like this before and the blonde isn't eager to let this go so quickly.

“Not pretending is an option,” Catra replies, fighting to sound very chill about all this.

She waits for Adora’s next idea (cause apparently, whoops, Adora actually *is* leading). To Catra’s disappointment, Adora moves from on top to situate herself next to her in the grass. It takes her a second to get comfortable, squirming around until she's leaning on her right arm, still just a breath away from Catra.

With shy but sure eyes, Adora reaches her left hand to relax casually against Catra’s hip.

Voice low enough to give Catra goosebumps, Adora asks, “So if we were *not* pretending, where would you like me to start?”

“I thought you were some worldly sex person,” Catra teases, before gently taking Adora's hand and lying it on the slightly thicker patch of fur on her chest, right between her breasts.



“There's gotta be a better name for that,” Adora jokes and even she can hear that her voice sounds shaky. Her fingers rake through the fur there, first just petting lightly before she gets bold enough to massage her deeply.

She might have noticed earlier that Catra's nipples had gone stiff but it seemed impolite to stare. Now, Catra's clearly straining not to push her tits directly into Adora's hands. Ever so slightly, Adora slides her palm across Catra's chest, a clear question in her eyes.

When all she gets is a hurried nod, Adora takes a nipple in her left hand and then the other one in her mouth.

'Welp, just jumping right into it, huh?' Catra thinks, still trying to joke her way out of this. There is absolutely nothing funny at all, not even a little bit about Adora's warm tongue teasing around her nipple before sucking it intently. Even if Catra wasn't already feeling raw and needy, nerves completely on edge (but like, in a good way, right?), Adora's touch makes her ache all over. She can't keep herself from arching her back, pushing for more as her claws dig uselessly into the grass next to her.

Adora's barely certain she's getting the hang of this, if Catra's swallowed moans are any indication, when her hand is wrenched away. Before she can ask if this is too much too fast though, Catra pushes it further down her body until it stops between her legs. Her fur is even softer here, something Adora had often wondered about. *Fantasized* about, honestly.

It's also damp down there. Like *really wet.* Tentatively, Adora cups Catra, just letting both of them get used to the idea for a long moment. Finally, when she can't take anymore waiting – and Catra is practically gritting her teeth to keep herself from squirming to get more contact – Adora uses her fingers to spread Catra open. She lets her thumb seek out Catra's clit.

Adora can admit that maybe she looked at some of the photos on Catra's tracker pad to fill in some of the blanks from her reading. It had helped her learn a bit about herself as well, but mostly she wanted to not be a complete fumbling mess in case she ever built up the nerve to make a move.

Whatever research she's done, Adora isn't actually prepared for the feel of Catra, wet and hot and throbbing in her hand.

"My Gods," she whispers, genuinely astounded that she can make Catra feel this way.

“Yeah,” Catra lightly laughs, though her voice sounds breathless. “Right there with you, princess.” She reaches up to grip Adora’s arm. “A little harder?”

Adora teases for a beat, ghosting her thumb back and forth across Catra’s clit until she gets the reaction she hopes for, a frustrated growl that would be a lot more threatening if Catra didn’t follow it up with big, pleading eyes. It feels impossible to deny Catra anything when she’s being this open and vulnerable so Adora pushes down slightly harder, circling Catra’s clit.

There’s some particularly vocal person nearby who’s screeching like she’s fighting off a wild beast. It would be nice to go over and shut this idiot up so that she can concentrate on Adora’s fingers but, *fuck,* Catra isn’t about to stop now. Adora’s hand has her weak in the knees yet tight all over, holding her breath for as long as she can stand it.

“Is this good?” Adora asks quietly.

‘Good’ isn’t quite an accurate representation of the best thing that Catra’s ever felt in her life but she finds the strength to mumble, “Yeah,” and has to hope that it comes out coherent. “More.”

“More?” Adora replies and Catra only notices she’s closed her own eyes when she realizes that she hears, rather than sees, Adora’s confusion.

Reaching down, Catra slides one of Adora’s fingers near her entrance.

“Oh,” the dummy replies. And then Catra is so full she could cry. “Oh! Oh, *wow.”*

Thankfully, Catra’s too preoccupied to see Adora’s face cause she’s sure she’d get made fun of. On top of sounding like a dork, Adora knows she’s sticking her tongue out and making the concentration face that Catra mocks her for all the time. But this is hard work! Not that she doesn’t have the muscle for it. It’s just a lot to move in and out while also trying to rub Catra’s clit at the same time.

They've waited so long though – *Adora's* waited so long, forever it feels like – and she just wants to make sure Catra has a good experience. The setting isn't ideal but that doesn't seem to bother anyone else, the constant sound of various people shouting out their own pleasure bouncing around the forest continuously.

Catra looks so gorgeous that it practically steals the breath from Adora's lungs. Head tilted back, fangs digging into her own bottom lip, she thrusts against Adora's hand, meeting every movement. It's silly but it most reminds Adora of how they've always sparred, matching each other's strikes, ducking and parrying, moving almost like one body. No one's ever been a match for her like Catra has.

"I love you," Adora whispers, overcome. She's held those words so closely since the Heart, feeling them grow each day but unsure how to move forward. Her fingers reach deeper, harder, wanting to make sure Catra really understands that they're true, that nothing's changed for Adora, that Catra's still the one.

"I-" Catra tries to respond. Her face suddenly wrenches, causing Adora to worry that she's being too rough until Catra groans deeply. *"Gods!"*

Adora delights in being able to bring Catra this kind of pleasure. For too long, her hands on Catra were meant with such different intent. This is so much softer (...kinda, Catra's really bouncing herself pretty hard against Adora's fingers and there's of course a little worry that she might pull something using so much effort.)

Touching herself usually goes pretty quickly since Adora's always had such a limited window of time, a couple of minutes in the cadet shower or a brief respite from saving the universe to blow off some steam. It's a welcome change to take her time exploring what Catra likes, trying different angles or speeds. There doesn't seem to be a single thing that Catra doesn't enthusiastically enjoy.

"You're, like, really sexy," Adora tells her. She never thought of herself as someone who'd be into dirty talk but it's always a big

hit in all of her books.

So close, Catra thinks. It's on a loop in her head. So close, so close. Each thrust from Adora is pure delicious torture. She doesn't know how long they've been doing this but it feels like she's been teetering on the edge of an orgasm for many many minutes. Hearing Adora say she loved her nearly pushed her over but some asshole in the distance whooped loudly and the feeling slipped away once again.

Catra feels the familiar buildup come back around again as Adora continues whispering Gods knows what. It sounds hot as hell but between her own heartbeat pouding loudly in her ears and the overwhelming amount of random sounds nearby, Catra can't pick out any clear words. Adora's voice is husky, a whole different register that Catra knows no one else gets to hear except her.

That thought alone gives her another near-crest before her orgasm floats just out of reach once more.

Slowly, the sensation fades away completely. Adora's touch is no less enjoyable but Catra becomes more aware – *too* aware – of her surroundings. Of all the people nearby. Of Adora's huffing from the exertion. Powerful warrior or not, this can't be very comfortable, especially after the dummy spent the afternoon overexerting herself to show off for everyone.

It's not gonna happen, Catra reluctantly admits to herself. That's fine. Not the end of the world. For a few moments, she continues going through the motions, trying to will herself to get back into it.

"Everything okay?" Adora asks, seconds into Catra's internal argument about whether or not to actually be a decent partner and communicate.

At first, she just nods back. Adora's movements slow and then stop altogether.

"Am I doing it wrong?"

“Of course not,” Catra says, struggling to catch her breath. “But that’s enough. Thanks.”

She moves Adora’s hand from inside to rest on her hip once more. When Catra opens her eyes, the blonde looks about one second away from a full frantic shame spiral.

“I gotta tap out,” Catra explains. Instinctively, she wants to glance away but she knows she has to keep herself locked on those big dumb honest blue eyes. “It's not a big deal. I really *really* enjoyed what you were doing, princess. There's just a lot happening at once. Can't really...let go, ya know?” To illustrate this, she makes a hand gesture, mimicking an explosion, that she’s sure Adora does not understand at all.

“I get it,” Adora replies, trying to sound like this is totally cool. It was going pretty well, she thought. She didn’t mean to mess up and make Catra-

“Hey, I know you’re used to acing everything but this wasn’t a test,” Catra tells her sternly. She winces and pauses, like that’s not at all what she meant. “Look. It was a well-fought battle and, even though we weren’t victorious, we got good intel. Once we regroup, we’ll probably have more success on our own soil.”

Adora stares at her for a moment, watching Catra’s tail thump against the ground, her eyes wide and waiting. “That’s a terrible metaphor,” she says honestly. Even Adora, who was a *great* soldier – she can’t really stress that enough – wouldn’t rely on a battle-based metaphor. Catra’s trying to make herself into a total dork for Adora and she can’t help but be filled with more love knowing that. “But thanks for explaining.”

She takes a look around at everyone still deeply in their world, writhing and pleasuring each other.

“Want to get some food?”

Catra glances over towards the feast table where 5 women are eating food off of each other’s bodies. “If you think I’m eating

here ever again, you're out of your fucking mind."

Adora giggles. "What about the Singing River? We can cool off. Maybe get some privacy?"

Adora remains the slowest person on the planet. Though she probably can't see a godsdamn thing as they get further and further away from the bonfire with nothing but the moons to guide them. Regardless, Catra doesn't give her a head start so she's already in the water by the time Adora finally stumbles out of the woods, looking completely disoriented.

"You cheated!" Adora yells.

"You're such a sore loser. Grow up!" Catra leans her head back into the water, letting her hair get wet. It's colder now that the daymoon isn't out. Honestly, it's refreshing since she felt like she was burning up from inside just minutes ago.

Like a total asshole, Adora takes a running start and cannonballs into the river, splashing water everywhere. Catra shrieks, completely unprepared to get drenched again. That settles it – this'll be the last time that Catra ever enters another body of water. Privilege revoked, effective immediately.

She moves to exit quickly, grumbling the whole way, when Adora emerges from under the water to grab her from behind.

"Come on," Adora coos, wrapping herself around Catra's back. "That was pretty funny."

"I hope you get eaten by a sea creature."

"Don't joke about that!" Adora hisses. "We don't know what's in here."

Catra tries to pull away but Adora's stupid strong arms tighten to hold her closer. She places a kiss on Catra's neck and, like a total traitor, Catra's body immediately reheats all over again. Typically

oblivious Adora somehow manages not to miss that. Catra can feel her smile when her lips begin trailing kisses up towards her ear, pausing only to push her mane aside.

"Is it quiet enough here?" Adora whispers, breath so close to Catra's ear that it sends a shiver through her.

It takes an incredible amount of willpower for Catra to pry Adora's arms from her and turn so they're face-to-face. Adora looks curious more than anything, a little worry mixed in.

"I'm gonna touch you," Catra states and chooses to take Adora's eyes going wide as dinner plates as a positive sign. "Okay?"

The blonde nods emphatically until Catra grasps her waist and pulls her closer. Quickly, the realization that she should have done as much research as Adora rolls through her head, but it's fine. Catra's only thought through a million different scenarios of this moment before. Keep her claws in and she's golden. Probably.

Trying to keep her hands from shaking, Catra slips one hand up into Adora's hair to tug her down into a kiss. Her ponytail's soaked and sagging so Catra goes right ahead and lets it down. Adora was always more gorgeous with her hair down anyway. She barely seems to notice, too preoccupied with kissing Catra like they weren't just making out for at least the last hour. Who is she to complain though? If Adora decides to spend the rest of their life kissing constantly, Catra will obviously (reluctantly) just have to resign herself to her fate.

Their kisses saved the universe. There must be some useful everyday problem that they can solve as well. Only one way to find out.

As much as Adora enjoys making out, she wonders if it would be selfish to ask Catra to touch her already. It sorta feels like sex is a specific set of steps that need to be followed in order to get the best resul-

"What are you doing?" Catra asks out of nowhere.

“Uhh,” Adora mumbles. “What?”

“You stopped kissing. Like your giant head started working so hard that your lips just shut down.”

“They did not!” Adora squawks while Catra laughs at her. Shyly, she asks, “Can you just touch me already? I got…pretty ready touching you.”

Mercifully, Catra decides not to tease her about that. She keeps her claws in Adora’s hair but trails her free hand down between the blonde’s legs. There’s a gentle poke. And then another. And then Catra just starts rubbing…something.

“Um. A little lower?” Adora suggests. She has to bite her lips to hold in her smile. They might both be clueless but Catra revels in being such a know-it-all that this is such a sweet comeuppance.

“I know where it is,” Catra hisses back. “It’s just…hard to feel things out when *everything’s* wet too.”

Adora chuckles, about to explain how there’s probably a distinct difference between the feel of the river surrounding them and, you know, *her pussy* when Catra’s fingers hit gold, bumping right into Adora’s clit. The words die in Adora’s throat.

“See! Got it!” Catra says triumphantly, like she knew exactly what she was doing all along.

Desperate for Catra to continue, Adora decides it’s best not to argue. Whatever Catra’s doing now anyway is working excellently. Adora feels herself slipping into that strange place between totally relaxed and completely taut, nerves aflame from her head to her toes.

Catra’s movements aren’t seamless, they stutter and stumble a few times. It’s hard to mind though. Earlier, when Adora was in control, she honestly was turned on enough that she thought she’d spontaneously orgasm if Catra just opened her eyes and looked in her general direction.

Slowly the motion of Catra's hand evens out, a rough but steady rhythm that makes Adora consider the consequences of not doing this on sturdy ground. The realization of how dangerous this is – that the only thing keeping her above the surface of the water is her own treading and already she feels herself losing control of her motor skills – just makes this even hotter.

Without what feels like adequate warning, Adora wraps her legs around Catra. So great, the person who has the least amount of swimming experience is in charge of both of their survival now. Adora "helps" at least by using her thighs to thrust onto Catra's hand. It throws Catra off again, since she'd just gotten the hang of this, but Adora's too far gone to notice. She sets a fast pace and Catra just has to keep up.

'Heh,' she thinks, snickering internally. *'Guess Adora* does *seem to know what hips are for after all.'*

All capacity for jokes – and thoughts really – disappears when Adora reaches up with both hands and yanks Catra's hair so roughly that she hisses. She'd thought this couldn't get hotter. She'd been very very wrong it appears. Adora leans down close, gasping right into Catra's half-open mouth.

Adora's moans begin coming closer and closer together in speed while her hips get more frantic. Catra moves her free hand down to grab Adora's ass under the very unnecessary guise of supporting her body.

There's some babbled nonsense coming out of Adora's mouth but the only part that matters, the part that Catra's gonna have burned into her brain forever, is her own name, desperate and pleading.

The grip on her hair gets so tight that it almost crosses the line from pleasurable to actually painful. Adora leans towards her mouth again but misses the mark and ends up placing a sloppy kiss on the side of Catra's lips and cheek right as her clit goes hard and then eases into deep pulses.

Adora remains frozen for a long moment, voice in one long final moan, as Catra's movements come to a stop. She moves her palm to cup Adora's clit, easing her through the aftershocks.

In the calm, Catra feels a purr drift up her throat, trying to angle her face away a little so she can see Adora’s serene smile. Her eyes are still closed and she looks just free and unguarded in a way that Catra’s never dreamt they could be, together or alone.

Slowly, the dark river begins to brighten. Vaguely, Catra regrets joking about sea creatures; on its best day, Etheria is full of odd, mysterious beasts. No need to tempt fate. The light continues up the surface, Catra’s worry growing, until she realizes it's bright gold and climbing up Adora's body to engulf her completely.

For a second, Catra panics. Glimmer had one clear rule and that was no She-Ra. How the hell was Catra supposed to know that *orgasms* were a She-Ra trigger? Then she remembers that this was all probably bullshit for Glimmer and the other two to lure them out here and figure their shit out. Or just get laid so they’d chill the fuck out, that's also a possibility.

Adora's glow dims soon as her head collapses against Catra's shoulder, remaining in her usual form. Good. Catra's not sure she'd be able to hold up She-Ra's weight anyway. Her arms are already tired and now seems like a good time for a nap.

The river feels oddly warm and suddenly animated, the previously still water picking up slight waves. She-Ra tends to have that effect on things. On one of their only rebuilding outings together, Catra gave her a dusty wilted flower as a joke, her first failed foray into romance, and She-Ra got so nervous that she accidentally turned the damn thing into a full rainbow-colored bouquet. It was so horrible and cheesy that Catra had to spend the rest of the day hiding to avoid everyone’s teasing.

Adora slowly comes back to herself until she's tentatively blinking her eyes open, a completely blissful and relaxed look on her face.

She opens her mouth to say something but is cut off when *the river* does the most frightening thing Catra can imagine.

It *sings*, high-pitched and grating, a sound that surrounds them on all sides and bounces off the mountain, echoing.

Looks like we made it
Look how far we've come, my baby

Catra misses the rest of the words, drowned out by Adora's sudden hysterical laugh.

"Yessss," she hisses. "It actually sings!" Adora has to cease laughing because it's getting hard to breathe and also to get a good look at Catra's disgusted face. "And you hate it."

It's even better than Adora had imagined. Catra's brows are shoved down, her nose and lips curled up, eyes filled with shock and horror. It reminds Adora of when Swift Wind took Catra for a tour of the stables to explain horse inequality. Catra got her first whiff of the stench and spent the next several hours complaining.

She's so precious and grumpy.

"I love you," Adora feels the need to tell her. "Always."

Even deeply annoyed, Catra can't help but grumble back, "Love you too."

"I want to be with you. Like this or however you want. Whatever you-"

"Really?" Catra interrupts, sounding hopeful and shocked.

You're still the ooooooonnnnneeee
The ooooooonnnnneeee *The ooooooonnnnneeee*

"Is it fucking harmonizing?!" Catra shrieks before pushing Adora's head underwater in her haste to get the fuck out of there. They

could figure out the details once they were safely on the ground and not tormented by evil rivers.

Mermista's convinced that she can separate the water molecules from the soda molecules or whatever in Sea Hawk's drink. All she's managed to do so far is make the war room table sticky and her boyfriend miserable.

"Dearest, perhaps this trick needs some additional practice," he suggests, watching the remainder of his beverage hover precariously in the air.

Mermista's eyebrows are bunched together in deep concentration as her hands outreach towards the liquid. It falls with a loud splash.

"Ugh! Stop distracting me," she whines.

"So, not that I don't love seeing everyone, cause believe me I do," Scorpia says. "Can *not* get enough of the ol' Princess Alliance. Back together, fixing problems, making memories-"

"Scorpia!" Glimmer interrupts impatiently.

Yes, she's well aware that these meetings are mostly useless but Adora *insists* on them. A chance for her to gather more duties, no matter how much everyone tries to wrestle them from her grubby hands. Entrapta doesn't even bother showing up anymore, not after Adora elected herself to deal with the decommissioned Horde bots and nearly destroyed Dryll.

"Right…are we starting anytime soon?" Scorpia asks timidly before trying to scooch down further in her seat in a futile attempt to hide.

"The first item on the agenda is Catra and Adora's debrief from their mission," Glimmer explains with as much patience as she can muster. She does not mention that it's also the *only* item on the agenda since everyone else is fully capable of communicating

effectively via tracker pad. Or just, you know, taking care of their own kingdoms without feeling the need to invent work for themselves. They were even making *casual,* friendly visits to see each other, no excuses about Alliance business. Certain magical heroes had not taken everyone's hints to begin doing the same.

In the week that the two have been gone, Glimmer's been able to get a decent night's rest, without Adora waking her up at dawn to inquire about some random task or Catra around to badger her all day. But she's still irritable, mostly from waiting for those two for the past 30 minutes. Why did they always insist on wasting her time?

It was weird that they didn't stay longer – Glimmer had half expected Catra to either sniff out the trick immediately or for Adora to spend a month there, imagining all sorts of evil clandestine shit until she returned and reported an occupancy issue or a noise complaint or something. Five blissful, mostly peaceful days away from those two assholes, her dearest friends who she loved more than most anything on Etheria. And if they didn't present themselves within the next 20 seconds, Glimmer was banishing them both so they'd be Frosta's problem.

Speaking of Frosta, she's now busy trying to see if she can freeze the water molecules from the spilled soda.

"I don't think picking such an early meeting time was good for them. Maybe Eras tired them out?" Netossa jokes. Spinnerella quietly shushes her but that doesn't stop her shit-eating grin.

"Eras?" Perfuma repeats. Her face twists up with a look of contempt. "Glimmer," she says in a tone that's a little too condescending. "You didn't."

"We," Spinnerella stresses, pointing to both Glimmer and her wife, "felt that Eras would be a good influence on Catra and Adora. You know how much she loves communication."

“And hedonism. It’s their-” Perfuma pauses to cut her eyes towards Frosta. “That environment might be a bit much for two people with so little experience.”

Spinnerella waves her concern off. “They were free to leave whenever they wanted. They stayed a few days. Clearly they had a good time. Eras really isn’t that bad, Perfuma.”

That just makes Perfuma completely lose her cool. “She desecrated the Heart Blossom! The things she made it witness!”

All eyes in the room fly towards her.

“What’s this now?” Scorpia asks.

Netossa smirks at Perfuma. “Don’t worry, Scorpia. We’ll bring you along next time.”

Perfuma chokes on nothing, her pale face turning bright red. “Why did you send them there? Of all places?”

“They needed to work things out.” Netossa answers.

Scorpia nods sagely. “Gosh, that is so true. You know, sometimes during the war, Adora would be attacking me and I'd think *‘we’re* fighting but what you're really battling is your own demons’, ya know?”

Glimmer takes a steadying breath. “Work things out *in their relationship.”*

Frosta pipes up to ask, “Wait. What's ‘hedonism’?”

“And why the fuck am *I* not invited?” Mermista asks, incensed.

Perfuma shoots a look towards everyone else that is filled with regret, outrage, and a plea for support simultaneously.

Fucking finally Bow returns. If the room isn’t tense enough, Bow’s completely shell-shocked face just adds to everyone’s confusion.

Without speaking, he quietly comes around to his usual seat, loudly pulls out his chair, and sits down, avoiding eye contact with all of them. There's several moments of odd silence before he speaks.

Ever so quietly, Bow says, "I think we can move on without them. Sounds-" His voice breaks, discomfort written all over his face. He swallows loudly and tries again, "Sounds like they'll be busy for a while."

Glimmer relaxes, collapsing back into the comfort of her chair. "Thank the Gods. Meeting adjourned."

Everyone breathes a collective sigh of relief.

"For how long?" Frosta asks.

Glimmer leans her head back and closes her eyes. "See you all next month. Everyone take a fucking nap. *Please."*

"I gotta say, bed's better than the grass," Catra comments with a clear smile in her voice. Adora crawls up from where she's made herself comfortable between Catra's thighs for the last hour or so.

For the first time since she joined Adora in Bright Moon, the blonde gets to watch Catra luxuriate in their bed – the big floofy one with too many cushions and pillows that they had to move into after Catra's claws "accidentally" cut into the more sensible one so many times that it had to be thrown out. With nowhere to be (though there's a strange sensation in the back of her mind that she had *something* scheduled today), Adora lets herself relax into the mattress while Catra arches her back, riding out the last waves of pleasure.

After the second night at Eraspolis, they'd decided to head out. Everyone was both sad to see them go and also eager to ask a whole lot of personal details on where they'd disappeared to during the ceremony. At Adora's suggestion, they'd marched back to Bright Moon, camping along the way and heading through

towns to see the sights for 3 days. They even managed to agree to a few things along the way: no more hiding, more talking, and torturing Glimmer for setting up such a ridiculous ruse instead of letting them figure things out themselves. There was no roadmap for where to go next in their relationship but they'd come to an understanding that they needed to face this together, rather than relying on old behaviors, falling into old patterns.

Reluctantly, Catra opens her eyes to find Adora looking at her expectantly. She knows she's purring so loudly that the bed feels like it's shaking. But the fun is probably over. Waking up to Adora offering to go down on her was a nice distraction from whatever pressing Alliance shit she has to run off to now.

"Time to go?" she asks, attempting to keep her voice neutral.

"Go?" Adora repeats. Her hand comes up to cup Catra's face as she moves closer. "Where am I going?"

"Well, first, you should probably wipe your face," Catra teases. To prove this, she swipes one finger across Adora's chin, collecting a lot of her own wetness off before cleaning it on the sheets. Adora just laughs. "Don't you have somewhere to be? Something to fix?"

Adora reaches her other hand to pull Catra even nearer. Looking into Catra's eyes, she says softly but resolutely, "There's nowhere I need be besides here."

They share a quick peck on the lips and Catra doesn't even complain about Adora getting her fur all wet.

"I'm gonna have that fucking song stuck in my head for weeks," Catra admits with a groan when they part.

"We have to go back," Adora tells her, full of too much excitement. "I wanna see if it knows other ones."

"Hell no. I'm not leaving this castle for weeks."

"This castle?" Adora chuckles. "I'm not letting you out of this *bed."*

Catra raises an eyebrow. “Is that a threat, princess?”

“That's a genuine promise,” Adora says confidently before pulling Catra on top of her.

Glimmer sends them food. It's the least she can do to thank them. By the third day though, she kindly leaves them an eviction notice so everyone can finally get some fucking peace and quiet around Bright Moon.

Chapter End Notes

> credit/blame to jezmatron for catra's bumbling during sex. no one is to blame for the cheesy ass song that the singing river sings except me unfortunately.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!